Dawn without the Sun

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Dawn without the Sun

by jumyouboshi

Summary

"Intra-Cognition is null. Responds only to destructive stimuli."

The sentence barely registers in Mydei's mind as he stares at the shadow of the man who was once Phainon, who sits completely still in a chair, dull eyes staring sightlessly ahead.

"Damage to mind function detected… Possibly irreversible…"

The Antikytheran-like man continues reading through the digitized logs impartially, as if merely reciting a speech. But every single word he says drives another stake into Mydei's heart.

Mydeimos the Undying scarcely bowed his head, rarely lowered himself onto his knees, and never, ever begged. And yet he finds himself doing all three things now, before the broken shell of Phainon, who is very much alive, and yet lacking all of the life that made him *him.*

Irontomb's birth is prevented, and Amphoreus is saved. But it's at great cost to Phainon, whose psyche finally crumbled under the devastating damage to his mind, body, and heart.

But Mydei and the other Chrysos Heirs will not accept this outcome. For what is a dawn without the sun?

Notes

So……. 3.4

Yeah……. I’m not okay…….
So I wrote this instead of working on the body sharing AU fsr???????

I'm also sufficiently sleep-deprived so I currently do not have any posting inhibitions. I originally intended to post this as a one-shot, but I think I might need more chapters (also i may be motivated to finish it more quickly if i post a little bit at a time)

I posted most of this chapter on Twitter already so if you follow me there, this should all be familiar... but hopefully still enjoyable! (????)

- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: [授翻/敌厄] 没有太阳的黎明（Dawn without the Sun） by Uryan_Karl
- Translation into Tiếng Việt available: Bình Minh thiếu vắng Mặt Trời by myphlvr (kkomattae)

Chapter 1

“I’ve located them. The admin logs on NeiKos496…on Phainon.”

He should be interested, but it’s all a dull roaring in his ears. The turmoil within him distracts him from much else.

“Intra-Cognition is null. Responds only to destructive stimuli.”

The sentence barely registers in Mydei’s mind as his eyes remain fixed on the shadow of the man who was once Phainon, who sits completely still in a chair, staring sightlessly ahead.

“Damage to mind function detected… Possibly irreversible…”

The Antikytheran-like man continues reading through the digitized logs impartially, as if merely reciting a speech. But every single word he says drives another stake into Mydei’s heart.

He can gather bits and pieces of what had happened, beyond the complicated outworld jargon. Mydei had died. All of the Chrysos Heirs had perished, giving their lives to pave the way for Deliverance. But the truth behind Amphoreus’ ill fate had been far crueler than any one of them could even imagine, the product of a lab experiment dressed up as an epic that was doomed from the very beginning.

In the end, to defy that fate, Phainon had willingly walked towards his own Destruction, all to ruin Lygus’ plans and give the world and the people in it a single chance at life.

Perhaps he would have been able to retain some semblance of himself had he simply perished as he had hoped and was restored alongside everyone else. But the forceful merging with the thing called Irontomb had destroyed what had been left of his fraying sanity. Defiant until the very end, Phainon had fought ferociously from within the Lord Ravager itself, buying enough time for the revived Chrysos Heirs and the Trailblazers to terminate its birth for good—

—but the immense effort he had expended to do so had been the final nail in the coffin on his already-damaged mind and body, leaving him in this near-vegetative state.

“It’s a miracle that we were able to restore him at all,” Mydei hears the Antikytheran man remark quietly to the Astral Express members, several of whom he does not recognize. The ones he does know, Stelle and Dan Heng, lower their heads, their expressions torn by remorse. “But as for whether we can restore his mind… While Madam Herta may argue that nothing is impossible for the Genius Society, I would advise you not to raise your hopes too high.

“33,550,336 cycles over hundreds of Amber Eras… It is difficult to fathom the insanity that this man has had to endure. Perhaps his sole saving grace was his nature as a data entity created from memoria—any normal organic being would have been destroyed in a fraction of the time.”

The conversation fades to background noise after that. Perhaps he should continue listening—it concerns his beloved, after all—but just this once, he is unable to muster an ounce of his indominable will to persevere. Not when he’s forced to hear about the cruelty and unjustness of it all.

Phainon was one of the three who fought for Amphoreus’ first true dawn. So why is it that he is the only one unable to witness it?

What point is there to a dawn without the sun?

“Mydei.”

A voice jerks Mydei out of his morose thoughts and he turns to see Dan Heng approaching. Beside him is another young man who appears to be around the same age, with shoulder-length grey hair, amber eyes, and, more peculiarly, a pair of wings sprouting from behind his ears and a metallic-looking halo floating behind his head. An older gentleman with brown hair and glasses accompanies them both, though an odd look enters his eyes the moment he sees Phainon. Mydei isn’t sure whether he likes the way he stares at him, but he holds his tongue. If they’re here to help, then he’ll be civil.

It’s Dan Heng who speaks first, introducing his companions. “These two are Sunday and Welt Yang, fellow Nameless who are traveling on the Astral Express. We were wondering if you were okay with us taking a look at Phainon.”

“Can you help him?” Mydei asks a little too quickly.

“We can’t make any promises,” the bespectacled gentleman, Welt Yang, replies. “But getting a better idea of his current state might guide us in the right direction.”

“Then, by all means.”

He steps aside, glancing down at Dan Heng and noticing the distinct lack of a second person by his side. “Where did Stelle go?”

“She left to brainstorm some ideas with March, Cyrene, and Black Swan,” Dan Heng replies. “They're trying to come up with a way to restore memory, since that might help bring him out of his state, but…we’re not sure if anything will work on Phainon just yet. His case seems to be very complex.”

Mydei tries not to let that shake him too much, instead turning to the other two. They’re discussing Phainon’s condition quietly, but their conversation is still audible from where he and Dan Heng are standing.

“Were you able to find anything, Mr. Sunday?”

The wing-headed boy, Sunday, shakes his head. “From what I can tell, there have been only a few instances of external interference, most of them stemming from the Lord Ravager. Otherwise, it’s as the others described—Mr. Phainon’s current state appears to be caused primarily by repeated instances of severe emotional and mental stress, resulting in lasting trauma… Although I cannot say anything definitive without performing an actual tuning on him.”

“No, it’s too dangerous. If he was touched by a Lord Ravager, or bears the power of one within himself, then there’s a high possibility that the tuning

will rebound and affect you, as it did with Miss Tingyun and Mr. Wonweek.”

“...That is certainly true.”

“For now, let’s try to find another way. Now that we have a clearer idea, we can narrow down our search.”

The unknown terms and names mean nothing to him. Mydei just knows that it’s not the answer he had been hoping for. But still, he holds his tongue, because he also knows that Phainon would never want to be healed at the expense of another person.

Their examination complete, Welt and Sunday finally step away from Phainon, turning back to Dan Heng and Mydei. Dan Heng, seeing that his companions are done, addresses them again. “What should we do next?”

Welt pauses, his eyes briefly falling on Mydei, who continues staring despondently at the unresponsive Phainon. Then, he places a hand on both Dan Heng’s and Sunday’s shoulders, gently pulling them aside. “Let’s touch bases with Stelle and the others first. I believe…we should allow Mr. Mydei some time alone with Mr. Phainon.”

Perhaps Mydei should reappraise this gentleman, if only for his tact. He makes a mental note of that for when he's in a better state of mind. In the meantime, Dan Heng and Sunday nod silently, allowing themselves to be guided away by Welt. As they walk away, Mydei hears traces of their conversation.

“Mr. Mydeimos and Mr. Phainon… Were they friends?”

“I think…they were a little more than that. So this might be quite hard on Mydei…”

“I’ve spoken briefly with the other Chrysos Heirs. It seems Mr. Phainon was very beloved among his companions. Most of them expressed similarly heartbroken sentiments upon learning about his condition…”

Mydei doesn’t hear the rest of what they say, but he neither wants nor needs to.

“My existence is of no consequence,” Phainon had once said. Mydei had not been close to him at the time and hadn’t bothered correcting him, but now he wishes he had. He wishes he could tell him now, show him that he *matters*, that he always did and always *will*, that he is and would always be an irreplaceable part of the Chrysos Heirs. And the indisputable proof of that is how much his fate had shaken all of them.

When he reaches over and cups Phainon’s cheek and receives no reaction, none of the receptiveness and gentle affections that he’d always get whenever he offered Phainon his tender touches, he feels the regret mounting.

Mydeimos the Undying scarcely bowed his head, rarely lowered himself onto his knees, and never, *ever* begged. And yet he finds himself doing all three things now, before the broken shell of his beloved, who is very much alive, and yet lacking all of the life that made him *him.*

Phainon is right in front of him, and yet he feels so unreachable that he may as well be dead.

“...Deliverer.”

He kneels, taking Phainon’s hands into his own. They’re warm, as they usually are, warmer than usual even, but they remain loose and limp in Mydei’s fingers.

“Deliverer.”

He presses his forehead to the backs of Phainon’s hands.

“Phainon.”

His voice grows quiet, so that he can conceal the tremor from the world, even if he can’t hide it from himself.

“...Please. Say something. *Anything.”*

Phainon doesn’t respond.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> I wrote a majority of this chapter at 5 AM in the morning, after being woken up by a burst of inspiration as well as my cat. If you see any weird mistakes and typos, blame my cat

Barely a day passes before Anaxa gathers the Chrysos Heirs to discuss Phainon's condition. Mydei and Aglaea are the first to show up at the allotted time and place, and the rest drift in closer to the agreed-upon hour. By the time the meeting commences, every Chrysos Heir has arrived—even the aloof Cipher, who remains in the shadow of a large pillar, watching and listening. Phainon himself is seated comfortably by the window, but his unseeing eyes remain fixed on one spot on the wall and unresponsive to any and all movements around him.

Anaxa clears his throat once the other Chrysos Heirs have settled into their places, commencing the meeting as if it were one of his lectures. "As you know, we have gathered today to discuss Phainon's condition. I will cut right to the chase—after more thorough examination, Hyacine and I have been able to corroborate what the outlanders have told us. Some of Phainon's current symptoms overlap with those exhibited by patients with severe traumatic brain injury. However… Because there were very few tangible causes, a complete recovery is highly unlikely, if not impossible, with existing treatment methods."

"Physically, Lord Phainon is completely healthy," Hyacine adds with a nod. "He's even capable of standing and walking without support, and he'll also chew and swallow if he's given food or water."

"Putting aside the fact that all of us, Phainon included, were restored with our status as demigods intact and have transcended beyond the need for most earthly necessities, we were able to confirm that, in some ways, Phainon actually fares better than most brain injury patients. And therein lies the current problem," Anaxa sighs. "It is exceptionally difficult to treat

a wound that does not exist in the corporeal world. In typical cases, we would have to rely on therapy of the mind instead… But as you can see, that's not possible either, as Phainon currently lacks the capability to perceive the world around him."

"So?" Cipher asks from her corner. "What do you suggest we do, Grove boy? Because all I'm hearing is doom and gloom."

"Do not interrupt me. I was just getting to that point." As he speaks, Anaxa slowly begins pacing from one end of the room to the other. "I posit two things. The first is that Phainon has suffered severe spiritual damage in addition to his brain damage, exacerbating the mental trauma he accumulated over 33,550,336 epochs. This is the main factor contributing to his current condition."

He pauses, scanning the conference room and waiting for any questions or challenges to his statement. He doesn't receive any—everyone is too demoralized by the assessment to say much of anything. Undeterred, Anaxa continues.

"The second… Is that while it will be incredibly difficult to reverse the damage, it's not impossible, as long as we take the right approach."

That prompts more of a reaction from those who have gathered. Mydei raises his head, but Aglaea is the one who speaks first, her tone terse.

"What are you proposing?"

"A multifaceted problem requires a multifaceted solution," Anaxa explains matter-of-factly. "Rather than trying to treat an illness with no cure, we need only turn our focus to what *can* be healed—the soul. The rest of Phainon's recovery should follow naturally, allowing us to handle the other aspects of his condition using more conventional methods."

"You speak as if the act of healing the soul is an easy feat," Aglaea continues, her eyes narrowing. "One that does not require your blasphemous research and heretical experiments."

“Ha…” Anaxa scoffs derisively. “I thought we were beyond these foolish debates. Answer me this, Lady Goldweaver. Are we really in any position to speak of blasphemy and heresy when *everything* we’ve ever known, including the pantheon that the people still cling so desperately to, has been turned upside down?”

The tension in the room reaches its head, palpable enough to cut through with a knife. Not a single person in the room dares to take a breath as the silent stand-off between Anaxa and Aglaea continues, though Tribbie fidgets, clearly wanting to intervene. Before she can, Aglaea crosses her arms, staring hard at Anaxa.

“Do forgive me for wanting to exercise due caution,” she says, her lips pursed. “But I simply dislike the idea of subjecting Phainon to more experimentation when he was…” She trails off, her fingers digging into her arms. “When he was already the primary target of Lycurgus’ cruel tests, and bore the consequences of them so that no one else had to.”

The room falls silent for the second time. Anaxa watches Aglaea with an unreadable expression, then sighs with a shake of his head.

“You really do have the lowest opinion of me,” he replies, maintaining an even tone. “I will obviously only use methods that are guaranteed to work. I’m not about to risk Phainon’s already fragile state with an experimental treatment.”

“Then can you assure everyone in this room right now that Phainon will be safe under your care?”

“Of course.” Anaxa allows for another brief pause before continuing, his voice softening. “He was one of my best students. Naturally, I would spare nothing *but* the best for him.”

Aglaea relaxes somewhat at that, letting her arms drop. “...Very well. If you can promise his safety, then you have my full support. Name the resources you require, and they will be provided.”

“...Oh? Now this is a surprise. Approving of my *heretical* methods is one thing, but you’ll be actively providing me with what I need? Have mountain goats started flying?”

“I’d advise you not to get used to this, Anaxagoras. These are outstanding circumstances. And I…” Aglaea turns, her gaze settling on Phainon. “I am willing to use any means necessary to ensure Phainon’s recovery.”

“Any means necessary…” Anaxa laughs through his nose, chewing on the statement. “I sincerely hope that it won’t have to come to that.”

The Chrysos Heirs disperse after that. Aglaea, Anaxa, and Hyacine reconvene to discuss their next course of action, while Cipher slips away without another word, with Tribbie following after her out of concern. Mydei lingers, intending to stay with Phainon until Anaxa returns, and he notices that Castorice hasn’t made to leave either. Instead of following the crowd, she had moved to stand beside Phainon instead, staring at him pensively. Seeing that she seems to be lost in thought, Mydei walks up to her.

“Castorice?”

“Oh…!” She starts a little, turning around to face Mydei. “Lord Mydei… You didn’t leave with the others?”

“No.” He doesn’t need to explain why. Castorice, the most staunch supporter of his and Phainons' relationship, immediately understands. “What are *you* still doing here?”

“Ah… Well…” She turns back to Phainon, who’s been still the entire time. “It was nice to see Lady Aglaea and Professor Anaxa talk at length without arguing… To see them putting aside their differences and working together,” Castorice says. “I was thinking, ‘Lord Phainon would be overjoyed.’ But when I saw him like this, I was struck with a powerful sense of loneliness… Surely, Lord Phainon must feel even lonelier than me right now, not being able to see or hear anything around him.”

Mydei looks down, trying to ignore the painful sting in his chest. He at least makes sure he doesn't let it show on his face—after his long tenure as the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, it's second nature for him to appear strong and stoic. "...He does get lonely very easily," he agrees. "Though he will rarely voice it."

Dispirited by the confirmation, Castorice looks down, clutching her dress. "Lord Mydei… Do you think Lord Phainon would protest if he were to receive an embrace from me?"

Mydei raises his head, observing the young woman quietly. Castorice had her curse removed with her restoration, and she had wasted no time in showering her friends and comrades in all the affections she couldn't give them before. However, she had been holding back with Phainon on the account that he would not be able to provide his consent. It's an act of consideration befitting a sweet, mild-mannered girl like Castorice, but it is a little saddening to see that she still has so little confidence in herself as a person—especially when Phainon had treasured her friendship dearly.

"I don't see why he would protest," Mydei finally replies. "He always expressed remorse that he wasn't able to do more to comfort you. I'm sure he would—" He falters for a split second. "I'm sure he would be happy to be embraced by you."

Reassured, Castorice nods, then gingerly wraps her arms around Phainon's shoulders. He remains completely still, not reacting at all, and her eyes glisten at the lack of response.

"...He's warm. As warm as I imagined him to be," Castorice whispers, pulling him a little closer. Unexpectedly, she continues speaking, perhaps spurred by her emotional state. "When he first arrived in Okhema, he was still so young. He was only as tall as my shoulder at first. Once, he referred to me as his 'big sister' by accident… He was so embarrassed about it, but that little accident warmed my heart and made me feel very happy…"

Her hold on him tightens still. "Ever since that day, I've always wanted to pat his head. Lord Mydei... Would he mind if I did it now?"

“...No,” Mydei says with certainty. “Not at all.”

Castorice nods again, then reaches up, gently tousling Phainon’s snow-white hair. Her lips curl into a soft but watery smile.

“He’s quite…fluffy,” she remarks, before hugging him once more. “One day… I hope to be able to do all of this when he is able to perceive these sensations.” She pauses. “Do you think that day will ever come, Lord Mydei…?”

She’s clearly looking for more reassurance, but Mydei has never been one to mince his words about chances and circumstances. The treatment that Anaxa had proposed is practically a shot in the dark, and even *he* hadn’t seemed completely sure that it would work. Mydei falls silent, mulling over how to respond, but he realizes quickly that there is only one answer.

They could not give up on Phainon. After all, Phainon had refused to give up on them—on the entire world—for 33,550,336 epochs.

“That day will come,” he replies resolutely. “Definitely.”

“...Mm.”

With that quiet agreement, Castorice nuzzles her face into Phainon’s hair, tears prickling at the corners of her eyes.

They remain like that in silence for a while longer, Castorice hugging Phainon, and Mydei standing silently by her side. Before long, the sound of footsteps breaks the silence, and both of them look up to see Hyacine approaching.

“Cassie. Lord Mydei.” She gives them both one of her smiles, though it’s more muted than usual. “I’m sorry… Was I interrupting anything?”

Castorice shakes her head, pulling away from Phainon. “No… Did Professor Anaxa or Lady Aglaea say anything about Lord Phainon?”

“They’re still discussing what to do next. Professor Anaxa said that he was thinking of contacting the Astral Express members before starting anything, since Dannie mentioned that there was someone on board who knew about mental healing, and another who knows a lot about memories.”

Mydei nods. The first one must be the wing-eared boy, Sunday. “I met one of them already. He came by to look at Phainon yesterday, but it seems like he wasn’t able to do much on his own.”

“Right… Dannie told us as much as well,” Hyacine says. “But we’re hoping that by combining the Nousporists’ research with the Astral Express’ capabilities, we’ll be able to make some progress. Lord Phainon’s condition is quite unique… So Professor Anaxa said we’ll need all the help we can get.”

“Is there anything we can do for Lord Phainon in the meantime?” Castorice asks hopefully.

“For now, Professor Anaxa told us to make him as comfortable as we can. That’s actually why I was here. Fresh air and movement will do Lord Phainon some good… And I thought we could take him to some of the places we’ve spent time together.” Her voice quivers slightly. “Just like our old days in the Grove.”

A melancholic look enters Castorice’s eyes. “...Yes. I agree. Perhaps bringing Lord Phainon to all of his favourite spots will trigger some of his memories, and bring him back to awareness.”

“That was my hope too.” Hyacine turns to Mydei, who has been hanging back quietly. “Lord Mydei… If you’re free, would you like to come with us?”

Mydei pauses, surprised he was considered at all. “I was never educated at the Grove. I have no place in your group.”

But Hyacine shakes her head. “That doesn’t matter. Lord Phainon really cherishes you… He always talks about you whenever he gets the chance

to," she says with a small laugh. "I'm sure he'd be happy if you were here too. But aside from that…

"Lord Mydei… You've been suffering too, haven't you?"

Taken aback, Mydei is temporarily robbed of anything to say. But he also finds himself unable to deny how devastating this entire ordeal has been and looks away. How did she know? It's a question that Mydei refuses to voice, but Hyacine smiles, answering him anyway.

"Even you can't hide what your microexpressions give away, Lord Mydei," she says knowingly. "I can see why Lord Phainon always referred to you as a kindred spirit or a soulmate… Beyond the similar experiences you share, you both have the same habit of swallowing your grief to appear strong in front of others…no matter how much you're hurting on the inside."

"...This shouldn't be about me," Mydei mutters. "It should be about Phainon."

"I know… But that's no reason why we should overlook our own pain. That's why, I'll ask again, Lord Mydei… Will you spend some time with the three of us, if you're free?"

Mydei finally raises his head, looking first to Hyacine, who awaits his answer, then to Castorice, who watches him hopefully…then finally, to Phainon, who has been silent and unresponsive the entire time, unaware of the conversation they're having.

Like this, Phainon seems like he can slip from Mydei's fingers so easily, and drift to a place where he will never be able to reach him.

He will not squander a single moment he could be spending with him. He refuses to.

Mydei brushes past Hyacine, approaching Phainon until he's right in front of him.

“Deliverer—” He pauses. That false title feels like ash in his mouth now, after all the pain it has caused his beloved. “...Phainon. Let’s go.”

He gently takes one of his hands and pulls him to his feet. With his guidance, Phainon stands easily. It’s as Hyacine had said earlier—he doesn’t need to be supported, but from his lack of reaction, it’s obvious that he won’t be moving anywhere without being led.

“Lead the way,” Mydei says to Hyacine. She nods, walking ahead, with Castorice following closely behind. Mydei gently pulls Phainon along with him, squeezing his hand to assure him that he’s there.

Phainon doesn’t respond.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> I am posting this past midnight because all my inhibitions are finally gone and I am no longer second-guessing myself thanks to my sleep deprivation ! But I barely proofread again so I'll leave that for the me of tomorrow. Why was this chapter like twice the length of the previous ones 😭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For the umpteenth time in a short week, an explosion rocks the depths of the Grove, shaking everything in the immediate area.

The golden threads shield Aglaea from the worst of it. Still, she’s left staring, unimpressed, as Anaxa stumbles out of the smoke, coughing and covered in singe marks from another failed experiment.

“I’m beginning to wonder whether you’re actually putting any effort into proving to me that your methods will work,” Aglaea says. “If so, you’ve done a spectacular job of convincing me otherwise.”

“How—how odd,” Anaxa retorts between wheezes. “There seems to be a —” He’s interrupted by another fit of coughing. “—a correlation between the success of my experiments and the presence of *distractions* currently in my lab.”

“Need I remind you who your current benefactor is? I don’t believe it is unreasonable for me to want some reassurance of your success.”

Finally recovering, Anaxa begins brushing the soot off his clothes. “Well, perhaps if you made yourself *scarce*, I would be able to focus more on perfecting my equations.”

“Enough, Anaxagoras. I know you’re using your own soul as the test subject of your experiments.”

Anaxa pauses in the middle of straightening out his tattered robes, then raises his head to regard Aglaea, his one eyebrow raised. “...Oh? And here I thought you would have had no understanding of the kind of work we carry out in the school of Nousporists.”

“I know enough on the matter of souls to understand what’s happening.” Aglaea narrows her eyes. “What you’re doing is incredibly risky.”

“I don’t suppose you’re about to suggest that I experiment on Phainon’s soul instead? Or worse, snatch an innocent bystander off the streets and turn them into my lab rat?” Anaxa crosses his arms. “Do you even have any right to be lecturing me when you had worn your own soul thin over the course of a thousand years?”

“...That was different.”

“It’s not different. Your hypocrisy aside, Phainon burned through *his* soul with hundreds of millions of coreflames, just so that we all could have a chance to live. It is only right, then, by the laws of equivalent exchange, that we are prepared to do the same for him.” He narrows his one eye, fixing Aglaea with a hard stare. “If you were in my position, you would be doing the same.”

Aglaea doesn’t deny it. She and Anaxa both know that she would. However, she doesn’t relent, crossing her arms and staring hard at him.

“And how do you think he would feel knowing that one of the very people he was fighting so hard to save had thoughtlessly thrown his life away?”

It’s Anaxa’s turn to fall silent. He stares at Aglaea, expression unreadable, allowing her words—her concern disguised behind the sharpened edge—to sink in, before laughing through his nose.

“Is *that* what this is about? Good grief… Might I suggest learning how to conduct yourself with some honesty?” He turns back to the ruined alchemic circle on the ground, crouching down to begin the process of reconstructing it. “Rest assured, my tests will have no lasting consequences on my own

soul. It would defeat the purpose if I wore myself away before I was able to find a cure for Phainon, no?”

“...So long as you understand. By the way, I was wondering if you happened to see Cifera...” She pauses, then turns to the door, where two visitors are waiting. “You two have been standing there for a while. Speak.”

Castorice fidgets awkwardly, and Mydei remains silent behind her. He’s heard of Anaxa’s and Aglaea’s infamous disagreements from Phainon, and he wants no part in them, allowing Castorice to speak in his stead. “We were looking for Lord Phainon when we heard the explosion… Is everything alright?”

“Nothing to worry about,” Anaxa says with nonchalance unsuited to the scale of the “mishap.” “Phainon is with Hyacine right now. They were on the second floor the last time I saw them.”

Castorice nods, and the two quickly depart before Aglaea and Anaxa can begin arguing again.

It takes some searching, but Mydei and Castorice finally locate Phainon and Hyacine in one of the Grove’s many libraries. To their surprise, Dan Heng and Sunday are also with them; Dan Heng is sifting through various tomes and scrolls, while Sunday seems to be discussing something with Hyacine. Phainon is seated at a sunlit window with Little Ica resting on his lap, and if Mydei didn’t know any better, he would think that he’s simply basking in the sunlight.

Noticing Castorice’s and Mydei’s approach, Hyacine looks up from her conversation. “Oh! Cassie! Lord Mydei! You’re earlier than expected…”

“Are we interrupting?” Castorice asks meekly. “If you’re discussing something important, we can wait.”

“No, not at all. Me and Sunnie were just talking about possible treatment options for Lord Phainon.”

Sunday blinks, his ear wings twitching a little. “...Sunnie?”

Ignoring Sunday’s reaction, Mydei steps forward. “Have you made any progress?”

“Yes!” Hyacine says happily. She’s definitely in higher spirits than the last time Mydei saw her. “We were able to come up with some ways to combine traditional healing with Sunnie’s powers as a…” She pauses, glancing at Sunday for confirmation. “A Harmony Pathstrider, was it?”

“That’s correct, Miss Hyacine. Of course, whether these methods work or not remains to be seen,” Sunday adds. “We were advised by Mr. Anaxagoras to wait until he finalizes his work before we attempt anything on Mr. Phainon.”

Dan Heng walks over, some books tucked under his arms. “We also talked with Black Swan, a member of the Garden of Recollection. She said that for now, we should just focus on helping Phainon’s mind heal before doing anything related to his memories. Having him remember everything at once is likely to do him more harm than good,” he adds. “In an ideal scenario, he wouldn’t have suffered memory loss at all, but with this extent of brain damage, that’s highly unlikely…”

Mydei falls silent. The possibility that Phainon would have forgotten about him, about all of them, makes his gut churn. Castorice looks similarly downtrodden at the notion, and Hyacine, noticing the atmosphere has taken a turn for the worse, quickly intercedes.

“Anyway… I think that’s enough for today,” she announces. “Dannie, Sunnie, thank you so much for helping us.”

“Sorry I couldn’t do more. I’m…not much of a healer,” Dan Heng says, and Mydei swears he can detect a hint of bitterness in his expression. However, Hyacine quickly shakes her head.

“Not at all! You sifted through all those books so quickly, and you were able to find the information that we needed… It’s thanks to you that we were so productive today,” she says.

“I concur. Mr. Dan Heng truly lives up to his name as the Astral Express’ Archivist,” Sunday agrees with a nod.

Although Dan Heng doesn’t look entirely convinced, his expression is coloured by the faintest traces of bashfulness, and he apparently decides to let the topic drop. “Well, anyway… Are you going to take Phainon on another outing? Don’t let us keep you. Just go on ahead—me and Sunday will clean up and find our own way back.”

“Thank you so much!” With that, Hyacine trots over to Phainon and takes his hand, gently coaxing him onto his feet. Little Ica floats off, drifting lazily to Hyacine’s side. “Come on, Lord Phainon. The weather is quite nice today, so we’re going to go to one of our old hangouts.”

“Ah… You mean the place we used to study together?” Castorice pauses. “...Won’t that bring back bad memories of Professor Anaxa’s exams?”

“Maybe. But it’d be a start, right?” She smiles sadly. “I’m sure that after everything Lord Phainon’s been through, memories of exam season are probably least unpleasant of the ones he could relive.”

“...That’s true.”

Hyacine gently leads Phainon over to Mydei, looking up at him. “Would you like to do the honours, Lord Mydei?”

Mydei nods, and Hyacine lets go of Phainon’s hand, allowing him to take it instead. It’s still as warm as ever.

The place that Hyacine and Castorice lead him to is a quiet outdoor area veiled by a curtain of overhanging branches and leaves—the perfect place for anyone who wishes to further their academic pursuits uninterrupted, and certainly a location that Phainon would classify as a “secret hideout.” In normal circumstances, he would have cheerfully told Mydei as much, and Mydei would be mocking him for his infantile fantasies, and perhaps they’d get into an argument after that, which would eventually turn into some sort of competition.

Now, seated beside the abnormally silent Phainon and still holding his hand, Mydei can only yearn painfully for those carefree days.

“Is something on your mind, Lord Mydei?”

He raises his head to see Hyacine leaning close with a knowing smile on her face, though still far away enough so that she’s not intrusive. Little Ica is right behind her, staring at Mydei with their beady eyes. Mydei looks away.

“Nothing in particular,” he lies, and knowing that she’ll be able to see right through it, he asks, “Where’s Castorice?”

The two girls had been talking about something or another before Hyacine had come over. Mydei doesn’t know what about—he hadn’t exactly been paying attention—but either way, Castorice is nowhere to be seen now.

“She noticed some butterflies, so she wanted to follow them. I’m guessing she wants to take a picture of them,” Hyacine replies. “May I sit beside you, Lord Mydei?”

Mydei doesn’t answer, but shifts to allow her more room at the table. He’s practically pressed against Phainon now, but he doesn’t really mind. They have done far more intimate things at this point.

~~When would they be able to go back to those times, when he could embrace Phainon, kiss him, and hear the sound of his soft laughter as he received his tender affections in return?~~

Hyacine sits down, still leaving a small gap between herself and Mydei despite the limited room. She’s quite a petite girl, so she doesn’t take up that much space. As she makes herself comfortable, Little Ica flutters over to Phainon and sprawls themself across his head. “Thank you, Lord Mydei,” Hyacine says. “I’m happy you were able to make the time to come out with us today, seeing as you’ve been so busy.”

Mydei nods again, still quiet. Castorice and Hyacine had been arranging outings daily, but other than the first time, Mydei hadn’t been able to

accompany them until today. Irontomb's ravages had left much of Okhema in disrepair, but not wanting to risk the existence of the surviving people, the Astral Express and Genius Society had decided against attempting to restore the holy city to its former glory—a decision that Aglaea agreed with. She had reasoned that with the combined efforts of all the citizens, they would be able to rebuild their home manually, fostering more camaraderie between the people in the meantime—all while allowing their allies from beyond the sky to focus on the most heavily corrupted parts of their world.

The Kremnoans—the ones that had survived and had already been restored, anyway—had heralded the return of their king, immediately flocking to Mydei's side, and he had recognized that in the chaos and tumult of Amphoreus' ongoing restoration, his people once again needed a leader. He could not possibly foist that responsibility onto Aglaea when she already had her hands full overseeing both Okhema's affairs *and* Phainon's treatment. So as much as it pained him to leave Phainon's side, he had placed his duties first, as always, making sure to direct his people as they aided with much-needed relief efforts around Amphoreus.

(When he asked, most of them had mentioned Phainon and how he had been helping them adjust to life in Okhema right up until the black tide struck the holy city. Mydei's heart both warmed and ached at the notion that the swordsman had honoured his final request to him before they parted ways.)

Mydei is grateful, at least, that Castorice and Hyacine had been undeterred by his constant absences and continued extending their invitations to him. Other than remaining by Phainon's side, there is little else he can do for him in this situation, and his utter powerlessness frustrates him.

"The scholar…" Mydei finds himself speaking. "Has he made any breakthroughs yet?"

Hyacine sighs softly. "Progress has been a little slow, but that's to be expected. Professor Anaxa is tackling a very difficult task." Sensing the Kremnoan's anxiety, she looks up at him with a small but reassuring smile. "But if it's one person who can succeed, it's him. He'll definitely pull

through. The fact that we have assistance from beyond the sky is a huge help too, so let’s keep believing in him.”

“...Right.” Mydei casts a sidelong glance to Phainon, who has remained still and silent beside him, then smiles crookedly. “...Phainon never hesitated to sing praises about that man’s intelligence.”

“Hehe… When Lord Phainon was still studying at the Grove, he’d get into trouble with Professor Anaxa the most out of all the students in class.” Hyacine giggles at the memory. “But in spite of that, I could tell that the professor was very fond of him. He’s always fair during lectures, but he really favoured Lord Phainon and Cassie above everyone else… So he’s no doubt working especially hard to find a cure for Lord Phainon’s condition right now.”

“Mm…”

The two fall silent after that, content to wait until Castorice returns from her impromptu excursion. However, Mydei suddenly feels the hair-raising sensation of eyes on him, eyes on all of them. Immediately on high alert, he sits up straight, his eyes scanning the surroundings for any sign of an intruder. Startled, Hyacine looks up at him again.

“Lord Mydei? What’s wrong…?” Her eyebrows furrow. “You have quite a frightening look on your face…”

He doesn’t answer at first. He can’t determine whether the person watching them is doing so with good intentions or not, and he doesn’t want to frighten Hyacine if it’s a false alarm… But there is undeniably someone observing them, and it doesn’t sit right with him to let this continue unacknowledged.

Especially with Phainon in such a vulnerable state.

“...I just have to go verify something.” Letting go of Phainon’s hand for the first time, he stands. “Stay with Phainon. I’ll be back soon.”

It doesn’t take him long to locate the culprit. Hunting a lion is a fool’s errand; Mydei’s senses have been primed from the long years he has spent in the wilds of Amphoreus, and though his search brings him quite a distance away from their gathering, he still manages to pin down the exact position of his prey. Striding over to a cluster of branches, he gives the culprit no chance to slip away, thrusting his hand through the leaves without hesitation. His fingers close around what feels like the back of a hoodie, snatching the hunter-turned-prey and pulling them out of their hiding spot in an instant.

It’s only when he hears the yelp and sees the cat’s tail does he realize that he’s scruffed Cipher. His eyes widen as he observes her dangling limply from his grip.

“You…”

Nonplussed, Cipher crosses her arms, though she’s unable to convey the extent of her displeasure from her position. “Yeah, it’s me! Do you mind?”

At that, Mydei quickly puts her down, and she makes a big show of dusting herself off. “Sheesh… That’s more like it. Kids these days… They really don’t know how to respect their elders,” she sighs.

“...You were watching us,” Mydei states flatly.

“Does that offend you, little prince?”

“Did Aglaea send you?”

She rolls her eyes. “Why is that your first assumption? She and I aren’t joined at the hip, you know.”

As callous as Cipher’s words are, Mydei can detect something else behind them, though he can’t quite put a finger on what it is. However, he does recall that Aglaea had inquired about Cipher’s whereabouts a few days ago, expressing worry because she hadn’t been spotted around Okhema in that time. The realization strikes Mydei then.

“You’ve been watching over Phainon, Castorice, and Hyacine throughout their outings.”

Cipher stiffens ever so slightly. To any normal person, her change in demeanor would be imperceptible, but very few things can escape Mydei’s sharp eyes. Recovering quickly, the thief shrugs and asks again: “Does that offend you, little prince?”

“...No,” Mydei replies more softly. “I want to thank you for keeping an eye on Phainon while I couldn’t.”

“Hmm~? Aren’t you jumping the gun a little? How naive.” Cipher hums, turning around and wagging her finger at Mydei, a mischievous smile on her face. “What if I was just waiting for the perfect opportunity to snatch his wallet? He’d be easy pickings for any thief, you know. Completely unaware of his surroundings, wouldn’t even notice anything missing… Now *that’s* what I’d call a perfect target!”

“You’re not the kind of person who would take advantage of someone like that, despite what you say and how you present yourself.”

The smile fades from Cipher’s face, replaced by a slight scowl. Clicking her tongue, she straightens up and crosses her arms. “We’ve barely even talked, and you’re already acting like you’ve known me your entire life? I used to think that you were pretty awesome, what with your death-defying capabilities, but you’re actually kind of pretentious.”

“You’ve looked after the children of Castrum Kremnos before. The ones who were with the Kremnoan detachment.”

Cipher goes quiet. Mydei continues.

“Don’t bother denying it. The thief who would often play with the children when none of the adults were watching, who would lead them to the juiciest fruits and warn them of the black tide’s encroachment… Based on their descriptions, there’s no one it could have been other than you,” he says plainly. “It seems I owe you for more than just Phainon’s safety.”

The thief clicks her tongue for a second time, turning away. “Why don’t you put your money where your mouth is? If you’re talking about repayment, then you’d better be ready to fork up the cash, little prince. Words are cheap.”

“Very well. Name your reward, and it will be delivered to you.”

Surprised that Mydei had agreed so quickly, Cipher groans. “Ugh, never mind. Your straightforwardness took the fun out of it. I guess that’s why you and the Deliverer boy get along so swimmingly, huh?” She shrugs. “Oh well. If that’s all, I’m going.”

“Then allow me to thank you once again,” Mydei says before she can leave. “On both my behalf…and Phainon’s as well.”

Cipher doesn’t answer. And in the blink of an eye, she’s gone.

A few days pass, and regrettably, Mydei once again finds himself too occupied to join the outing that Hyacine and Castorice had arranged for the afternoon.

He knows he can't shirk his duties, but having to reject their invitation today feels a little worse than usual. His gut feeling keeps telling him that he should go with them—the two were planning to travel to the outskirts of Okhema with a caravan to help deliver supplies and provide aid to anyone in need, and while Hyacine had believed that a change of scenery would do Phainon some good as well, it doesn’t sit well with Mydei to let him go so far away without accompanying him.

Still… Castorice had also gone with them. Though she is now freed from her curse, her dominion over death remains the same. She is more than enough to protect Phainon, Hyacine, and the civilians they're traveling with in the worst case scenario. And if not, Hyacine had promised to text Mydei on the unlikely occasion that they ran into danger.

So why does the dread in his heart grow, not abating no matter how much menial labour he carries out alongside his people and Okhema’s citizens?

Try as he might to brush it aside, it lingers, persisting even as the hours drag on by, not dissipating even when he's given more tasks or when the Kremnoans come to him for guidance and request his leadership. But half the day passes uneventfully, with no news of anything happening from within or without the city, and he hasn't received any messages on his teleslate either. Hyacine and the others should be back within the hour, and that knowledge helps Mydei's mind settle a little.

Unfortunately, like always, his intuition rings true. While he's placing a pile of wooden beams down—more building materials needed for the many homes still in need of repair—the wind whips by him abruptly, and before he can write it off as an errant breeze, he sees Cipher in front of him, slightly out of breath. There’s a frantic look on her face that immediately strikes a strange sense of fear in Mydei’s heart.

“Bad news. The black tide struck where the Deliverer boy and the girls went,” she says breathlessly, not even bothering to conceal the fact that she had been tailing the group again. “There’re too many for me and Princess Homebody to handle on our own. We need help, and *fast*.”

Mydei feels his blood turn to ice in his veins.

The outworlders had warned the Chrysos Heirs of this risk already—the possibility that creatures of the black tide, remnants of Irontomb’s will, could still appear, and though they were lesser in number and could be vanquished permanently, they still posed very much of a threat to all lifeforms.

Hyacine had specifically chosen to embark on this excursion with Phainon because the area they had gone to was *known* to be safe from the black tide. She would never do something as irresponsible as endangering one of her patients.

This must have been some kind of freak accident that no one could have foreseen.

I should have gone with him.

That’s the only thought that occupies the god-king’s mind as he turns back to Cipher.

“Take me there,” he says urgently, for once uncaring of the fact that he’d be abandoning his post, but if there are lives on the line, surely the others would be understanding. Cipher doesn’t waste any time either, grabbing his arm with one hand and flipping her coin with the other. The journey is over in a fraction of a second, Okhema’s scenery morphing into a suburban landscape before Mydei can even draw breath.

He had once thought that the divine speed of Trickery would leave him feeling nauseated, but the trip had actually been smoother than he imagined. On the other hand, Cipher is clearly exhausted, doubled over with her hands on her knees as she gasps for breath. “Ugh… Sheesh… Has anyone ever told you how heavy you are?”

Mydei doesn’t answer, scanning the surroundings from the hillside Cipher has brought him to. The area is…eerily silent, not at all like the chaotic battlefield that Mydei had been envisioning. But as his head swivels around more, he spots corpses upon corpses of black tide beasts, he realizes that it’s because he’s not looking at a battle in progress, but the aftermath of a one-sided slaughter.

“Where’s Phainon?” he asks.

Cipher raises her head, staring up at him incredulously. “How am I supposed to know? He was down there with the others just now…”

Seeing no point in answering, Mydei quickly descends down the hillside, his heels raking through the grass and dirt as he allows gravity to carry him to the base. There’s still not a single sound that can tell him where Phainon and the others have gone, so he decides to follow the corpses of black tide beasts instead, not checking to see if Cipher is behind him. Eventually, Hyacine comes into view, along with Little Ica and the civilians huddled around her, and Mydei wastes no time in running over.

“Hyacine.” He announces his presence with the call, his calm tone belying the growing franticness he feels. Having been in the middle of healing an

injured man, Hyacine's head snaps up, her eyes widening with both shock and relief when she sees Mydei kneeling down beside her.

“Lord Mydei…” Her eyes flick to a spot behind him. Cipher must have finally caught up with him. “Lady Cipher…” She sounds a little shaken, but a quick glance-over tells Mydei that she’s completely unharmed. That’s a good sign. “How did you two…?”

“Never mind that. What happened?” Mydei asks.

“The black tide began surging out of nowhere all of a sudden…” From the look on Hyacine’s face, she seems to be torn by guilt. “I don’t know what could have caused it. There were never any reports of its encroachment near this area…”

“It’s not your fault,” Mydei quickly says to reassure her. “No one could have predicted this would happen.” He pauses, his eyes traveling over the group that has gathered around Hyacine. Phainon and Castorice tend to stand out, and the fact that he spotted neither of them immediately tells him all he needs to know. “Where are Phainon and Castorice?”

“Cassie is scouting the area just in case there are more black tide monsters. As for Lord Phainon, he’s…”

Hyacine raises her head, looking off into the distance. Mydei follows her gaze to a scene of absolute carnage, where even more black tide beasts lie dead, some intact, others hacked to pieces, and others still mutilated until they are barely recognizable.

And at the epicenter of it all is Phainon.

Unharmed but completely still, he’s not facing the group, but he seems to be staring blankly ahead, his clothes flowing listlessly in the light breeze. Dawnmaker is still in his hand, nearly slipping from his loosening grip.

Mydei doesn’t know what to make of the scene.

“...Phainon?” he whispers. “Why is he…”

Before Hyacine can say anything, the man she is healing raises his head. “Lord Phainon… As soon as the black tide beasts drew closer to him, he suddenly leapt into action,” he says, his eyes shining with awe. “It was incredible! He tore through their ranks so quickly, as if it was as easy as breathing! He may have fallen still now, but the way he moved before... It was as if a silver storm had descended upon the enemies! His strength and skill are the stuff of legends!” The man’s voice quivers as he finishes recounting the tale, a gleeful smile spreading across his face.

“No matter what, his heroic spirit lives on! He really is Amphoreus’ Deliverer!”

That declaration stings more than Mydei realizes is possible. Perhaps it's because it's uttered without consideration for what that heroism had cost Phainon.

The man must know of Phainon’s condition. Most Okhemans do—it would've been impossible to hide it, when he had been so involved around the city, had charmed and befriended virtually every citizen with his sunny smiles and his willingness to drop everything to help anyone in need. But none of them then would never truly know about the horrors he has been through—the way that Lygus had toyed with him like a lab rat, until his body had been reduced to charcoal and bone and his mind had but a single shred of sanity left to cling to, sustained only by equal parts hatred and love.

They will never really know the truth behind Phainon’s current state.

“Intra-Cognition is null. Responds only to destructive stimuli.”

Mydei remembers the words as clear as day, and he knows immediately that Phainon had only responded to the threat because it's *muscle memory* for him to meet destruction with destruction.

There is nothing left of him but that primal instinct—all the other parts of him had long been shaved away by the millions of iterations of his past selves and the heat of the coreflames that had consumed him for an equal amount of epochs.

That realization is almost as devastating as if Phainon had simply fallen to the beasts in his vulnerability.

Silently, Mydei stands up and begins walking over. Though Phainon doesn’t move, there’s a part of him that fears that he will vanish right before his eyes, and the unwanted thought prompts him to quicken the pace. Luckily, no such thing happens, and Phainon remains where he is until Mydei circles around him to face him. His blue eyes are still dull and unfocused, staring right through him, and his expression is blank. Nothing has changed.

“...Phainon.”

Mydei slowly wraps his arms around Phainon, pulling his head into his shoulder and holding him there gently.

“They’re all gone now,” Mydei murmurs into his hair. “Let’s go home.”

Phainon doesn’t respond.

Chapter End Notes

don't worry be happy

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> I was a little nervous about including Cyrene in this since we don't know much about her yet, but hopefully she feels in character! At any rate I'm sleep-deprived again so I have fewer inhibitions about posting
>
> Also these chapters keep getting longer when I meant to keep them short... Hopefully it's a good kind of length though!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In spite of his many setbacks, Anaxa had apparently managed to reach an epiphany in record time, and within the next week, Phainon’s treatment officially begins.

It’s been two weeks since then. Mydei can’t be beside him at every session, a fact that pains him. However, Okhema’s repairs are also coming along smoothly, leaving him with more free time than before. Finding himself blissfully unoccupied one afternoon, he decides to head to the Garden of Life, where he was told Phainon is currently resting. As he nears, he hears a child’s humming, and upon emerging from the elevator, he sees Phainon sitting in the shade of the largest tree, with Tribbie and Trianne weaving flowers together, and Trinnon perched on a seat nearby, singing a soft melody. Upon his approach, Trianne raises her head, and her expression brightens.

“Look, it’s De!”

“Shh, Trianne, don’t be so loud!” Tribbie chides. “Naxy said we should stay quiet around Snowy so we don’t disturb him while he’s resting.”

“Oh! Whoops…”

Mydei manages a muted smile at the innocent sight. “Have you been taking care of him?”

“Mmhm! Snowy’s treatment started, so he must be really tired! Naxy and Cinny may be gentle, but doctor’s appointments are always scary for everyone. Even Naxy said he might be under a lot of stress, even if he doesn’t show it,” Trianne says. “Snowy needs a lot of rest in general, after everything he’s been through… That’s why we want to help him relax. So we always try to spend time with him after every treatment!”

“Whenever Snowy got anxious as a child, we would sing songs for him to calm him down. He seemed to like them, especially the ones Trianne sang,” Tribbie explains. “But Trianne’s been singing for him a lot, so we’re giving her vocal chords a break today. This time, it’s Trinnon’s turn.”

Trinnon pauses her humming briefly to add, “We hope that Snowy still likes our songs, even now. Even if he may not remember them anymore.”

“I’m sure he does,” Mydei replies. “He would never forget something so meaningful.”

The three exchange a smile before looking back at the former crown prince. “Would you like to stay with us too, De?” Tribbie asks.

“If you don’t mind.”

“Not at all! Snowy loves you, so he’ll relax even more if you’re here!”

Mydei allows himself a small chuckle. If Phainon were at his prime, he’d be doing anything *but* relaxing in Mydei’s presence. Closing his eyes, Mydei can imagine it now—upon seeing him, Phainon would leap up from his chair and immediately challenge him to whatever nonsensical duel he had been brewing in his mind. And Mydei, never one to refuse a challenge, would accept, and they’d lose themselves in the spirit of competition, at least until Aglaea caught wind of their shenanigans and scolded them.

When Mydei opens his eyes, he almost expects that to be the sight that greets him. But instead, Phainon remains doll-like and still, not even reacting to his rival’s presence. Feeling a powerful ache in his chest, one that has become far too familiar ever since the world had been restored, Mydei sighs softly and walks over to join Phainon in the shade, finding a

spot against the tree trunk to lean on. Rather than mull over his dispiriting thoughts, he decides to observe Tribbie and Trianne instead. Tribbie is still in the middle of her flower crown, but Trianne has finished hers, holding it up proudly for Mydei to see.

“It’s done!” she declares. “De, look! We chose all of Snowy’s favourite colours today. They’ll look really good in his white hair, don’t you think?”

“...Ha. Impressive. Somehow, you managed to coordinate the colours perfectly. Had the task been left in Phainon’s hands, he surely would have made this combination look utterly garish,” Mydei replies with a small smile. “He could stand to learn a thing or two from you.”

Basking in Mydei’s praise, Trianne flashes a toothy grin, then flutters behind Phainon’s head to crown him. “Okay! Trianne’s gonna put it on now!”

However, Tribbie looks more doubtful, flitting over to examine the crown as well. “Are you sure it’s ready? Some of the stems look a little loose… We already told you that you have to tie them a certain way or else the whole thing will fall apart…”

“It’ll be fine! Look—wah!”

As Tribbie predicts, the flower crown unravels barely a minute after it’s been placed on Phainon’s head. Some land on the grass, others slowly drift down onto his lap, creating an unintentionally picturesque scene. Still, showering Phainon in petals had not been their end goal, and Trianne looks dismayed at the sight of the flowers strewn all over the place.

“Ahh! We told you, Trianne!” Tribbie cries. “Come on, let’s pick them up! We’ll show you how to do it again, so make sure you pay attention this time!”

“Okay, okay…!” Pouting a little, Trianne reaches for one of the flowers on Phainon’s lap, but as she does, she pauses. “...Huh?”

Sensing her hesitation, Tribbie looks up from her own task. “Trianne? What’s wrong?”

“Just now… Snowy’s eyes moved.”

Startled, not entirely believing what he just heard, Mydei immediately pushes himself from the tree trunk and stands up straight. “...What? Are you certain?”

Not answering at first, Trianne plucks a bright yellow flower off of Phainon’s lap, raising it above her head, then allowing it to drift back down. Sure enough, Phainon’s eyes flicker, and though he doesn’t seem to be able to follow the flower all the way, he’s clearly staring at it, rather than looking blankly ahead as he usually does.

“His eyes really did move!” Trianne exclaims. “Does that mean he can see now?!”

“We should tell Naxy,” Trinnon pipes up.

“I’ll contact him right away,” Mydei says, already pulling out his teleslate.

For the first time in what feels like an eternity, he feels the beginnings of hope sprouting in his heart.

News spreads throughout the Chrysos Heirs fast, but in spite of the excitement over Phainon’s improvement, Anaxa is insistent that Phainon is allowed the opportunity to get an adequate amount of rest following his last treatment, announcing that they will reconvene in three days time. Those days pass by slowly for Mydei, who remains by Phainon’s side but is unable to curb his restless energy. Phainon is, without a doubt, beginning to be able to track some movement now, and the knowledge that Anaxa possibly has a plan in mind to expedite his recovery makes the wait even more agonizing.

Finally, the day comes, and a small group gathers at the Grove once again, most of them familiar faces. Castorice had accompanied Mydei and

Phainon today, and the three meet Hyacine and Anaxa in front of the sage's lab. Sunday is also there, this time accompanied by Stelle and a short pink-haired girl he doesn't recognize. Upon seeing Stelle, Castorice seems to light up.

"Oh…! Stelle…"

She fidgets a little, clearly wanting to ask for something, but apparently not having the courage to do so. Thankfully, Stelle seems to know what she wants and opens her arms with a goofy grin on her face.

"C'mere."

Smiling, Castorice eagerly obliges, running into Stelle's arms and hugging her tightly. Then, not wanting to leave anyone else out, she hugs Hyacine, who receives her embrace happily, then Little Ica, who lets out a cheerful trill, and finally Anaxa, who doesn't really reciprocate as strongly but pats her on the back nonetheless. She pauses as she turns to Sunday, but he smiles softly and opens his arms slightly, allowing her to hug him as well. Mydei raises his eyebrows, surprised that a shy girl like Castorice would be so willing to embrace someone that she barely knows, but he's also aware that she's been spending more time at the Grove lately, so maybe she and Sunday have had the chance to speak during the times he had been collaborating with Anaxa.

"Awww!" The other pink-haired girl coos when she witnesses the sight. "Do I get one too?"

Castorice lets go of Sunday and turns to the unfamiliar girl, looking unsure of whether a stranger would appreciate her embrace. "Are you alright with it…?"

"Of course! How could I say no to a pretty girl?"

Castorice blushes at the compliment, but seems to be reassured by the smaller girl's sweet smile and hugs her as well.

“I’m sorry… I don’t believe I know your name,” Castorice admits as she pulls away.

“Oh? Has Stelle been keeping me a secret from everyone? Even though she’s told me about all of you.” She glances coyly at Stelle, who looks away with a grimace, before turning back to Castorice. “Oh well. My name is Cyrene. It’s nice to meet you!”

The name sparks some recognition in Mydei. Phainon had mentioned that name before—it had been during the aftermath of their hot bath competition. Cyrene had been one of the people murdered by the Flame Reaver during the Aedes Elysiae disaster—putting aside the fact that the Flame Reaver had *also* been a version of Phainon. He doesn’t want to think too much about that fact right now, and instead focuses on the most important thing:

“You’ve known Phainon since before he came to Okhema.”

“Mmhm. Since he was a little boy, in fact. Even though his body is so big now, it doesn’t seem like he’s changed much.” She smiles warmly, turning to where Phainon stands quietly. “I mean, just look at him… At some point, he started trying to act all tough and grown up, but no matter how tall he gets, he still ends up getting fussed over by everyone around him.”

Mydei follows her gaze. While the others were carrying out their greetings and introductions, Anaxa and Hyacine had moved to Phainon’s side, assessing his current condition. Cyrene is right, he muses. Phainon does have the uncanny ability to endear himself to other people, whether it’s intentional on his end or not.

If only he could see how much he’s loved right now.

He’s shaken out of his thoughts when Anaxa and Hyacine approach the group again.

“Hyacine and I have confirmed that Phainon now has the limited ability to track movements. This means that he’s responding well to his current treatments,” Anaxa says. “Now that we know that what we’re doing is

working, we can move onto the next phase.” He glances at Sunday. “Are you ready?”

Sunday nods. “I am prepared to begin at any time.”

“Good. Follow me.”

Anaxa heads into his lab, beckoning for Sunday to follow, though Hyacine lingers with the rest of the group. Mydei hasn’t seen her since the black tide incident, and though she looks like her usual self, he decides to ask anyway. “Are you alright?”

Hyacine looks up at him with a gentle smile, immediately knowing what he’s inquiring about. “Professor Anaxa asked me the same thing after we got back from our trip. But I’m fine. The one we should be concerned about is Lord Phainon.”

“Yes, but we should not disregard our own pain. That is what you told me before.”

“Hehe… You’re very considerate, Lord Mydei. I never expected you to use my words against me.” Her expression warms. “But I promise, I’m fine. I wouldn’t be much of a healer if I let a little setback like that get me down. The three of us have gone on several more outings since then, and they all went well. And now that Professor Anaxa has made some progress, I can focus on actually treating Lord Phainon.”

“I see. But if you three plan another excursion in the future, I’ll come. I’m not needed as much around the holy city anymore, so I have significantly more free time than I did before.”

“Oh, that’s great! I’m sure Lord Phainon will be especially pleased to see you with us,” Hyacine says happily.

“Hyacine,” Anaxa calls from within the lab. “Everything is set. Can you bring Phainon in?”

“Coming! I’ll see you in a bit, Lord Mydei.” Hyacine nods at Mydei, then to Stelle and Cyrene. As she takes Phainon’s hand and leads him into the lab, Cyrene hums.

“Hyacine is really cute,” she remarks. “A get-together with me, her, and March would be quite something, don’t you think?”

“Are you talking to me?” Stelle asks, crossing her arms. “Why am I not invited?”

“Feeling left out? You *could* join us, but you seem like you’d enjoy roughhousing with Phainon more,” Cyrene replies with a giggle. “If it’s just the three of us, *I’m* the one who’d get excluded!”

Mydei looks at Stelle, outwardly acknowledging her presence for the first time. “You’re here as well.”

“I mean, it’s Phainon, so…” Stelle says. “Also, Dan Heng’s busy today, and someone had to make sure Sunday didn’t get lost on the way to the Grove. *And* Cyrene wanted me to show her around Okhema now that it’s been mostly repaired, so I’ll be roleplaying as a tour guide later.” She scratches the back of her head. “But Phainon’s the one who knows the most about Okhema’s best sight-seeing spots, doesn’t he? He gave me and Dan Heng some tips when we first landed here… I’ve also read some of the stuff he’s written on the World Wound Web, and it was all pretty in-depth. He must’ve put his whole heart into those blurbs.” A beat. “Actually, the more I think about it, the more I feel like he’s the best person for the job…”

Cyrene giggles again. “Then we’ll just have to make sure Phainon gets better soon, so he can show you how it’s done.”

“Yep. There are some people you really can’t replace…”

Mydei and Castorice lower their heads, finding themselves in silent agreement with Stelle’s statement.

Some time later, Anaxa emerges from the lab looking no worse for wear. “We’re done.”

“How was it?” Mydei asks.

“The treatment itself proceeded without a hitch, but as for whether it’ll actually work, we’ll have to see. It’s likely that the results will be slow to show, as they were for the first phase of treatment.” Anaxa glances back into the lab, and Mydei follows his gaze to where Phainon is seated on a comfortable chair, Hyacine holding his hand and Sunday standing beside him. Stelle peeks in too, raising her eyebrows.

“Huh. Sunday looks totally fine. How’d you do that? The last time I saw someone using mind powers on a Lord Ravager’s victim, they got really messed up.”

“Sunday explained his powers as a tuner in great detail. Naturally, I developed safeguards that were in place throughout the entire treatment. They were sufficient to protect his soul from possible rebounds,” Anaxa replies matter-of-factly. “Now, if you’re planning on bringing Phainon back to Okhema today, I advise you to wait for at least one hour. It would be better for him to avoid excess stimulation so soon after treatment.”

“I’ll stay with him,” Mydei immediately volunteers, then looks at the others. “The rest of you can return to Okhema, if you wish. We’ll catch up later.”

“No, no, we’ll wait too. Right?” Cyrene says, glancing around, and the others nod in agreement. Then, she turns to Stelle with a wink. “We wouldn’t want Phainon to miss Stelle’s debut as a tour guide, after all!”

Stelle huffs. “With how much you’re hyping me up, I’m gonna have to start charging for tickets.”

In spite of all the jokes, Mydei is silently grateful that Phainon will have so many people waiting for him when he truly awakens.

The next few sessions, which are carried out over intervals of three days, proceed in a similar fashion. Mydei is always there to accompany Phainon, leading him to Anaxa's lab before the treatments begin and staying with him after they're over. Today is the same, and as Mydei wiles away the time waiting for Phainon to finish resting, Anaxa approaches him.

"Mydei. A word, if you will."

Mydei looks up from the bench he and Phainon had been sitting on. "What is it?"

"Where has Phainon been staying since Amphoreus' restoration began?"

"Aglaea set aside private quarters for him in Marmoreal Palace so that she and Tribios could attend to his needs at any time."

"I see. I thought as much. That's not a bad arrangement, but today, I suggest bringing him to a more familiar environment. Somewhere like his home, though I'm sure yours would suffice too."

It's quite telling when most other people automatically assume that Phainon and Mydei frequent each other's residences. However, it is true that they exchanged the keys to their respective homes long ago. Mydei had let himself into Phainon's abode on more than one occasion, and it's the same for Phainon. That's why he focuses not so much on *how* Anaxa knows, but *why* he's making the suggestion in the first place.

"Did something happen during his treatment?" he can't help but ask. He must sound more worried than he intends to, because Anaxa flashes him a brief but reassuring smile.

"Yes, but it was a good thing. Phainon exhibited more awareness today than in previous sessions, and he was actively observing his surroundings. Both Hyacine and I agreed that it would do him some good to recuperate in the comfort of his home—or yours," Anaxa adds.

"I see…" Mydei allows his shoulders to relax. "Alright. I'll bring him back to his home today."

One hour passes, and Mydei manages to hail a passing dromas caravan en route to Okhema. The trip passes by uneventfully, but Mydei keeps an eye on Phainon the entire time. Anaxa had said that he had been observing his surroundings, but while he does seem more alert than usual, not much else has changed about him. He supposes it's to be expected—like Trianne had said, the treatments are bound to have a fatiguing effect on Phainon's already damaged mentality, so Mydei convinces himself to stop fretting.

By the time they disembark in Okhema, it's already the second quint into the Action Hour, and the streets are bustling as usual. Having had years to hone his reclusive tendencies, Mydei leads Phainon through the most quiet stretches of the holy city—a long but necessary detour if he wants to avoid exposing the broken saviour to the cacophony of the crowds. He does make a few stops along the way to pick up some fresh groceries, though. Phainon hasn't been home in more than a month, and most of the perishables in his pantry would have spoiled by now. It normally wouldn't matter, for as the demigod of Worldbearing, he would no longer perceive hunger, but good food would bring comfort to anyone, even the divine, especially if they are suffering from an ailment. And of course, there is also a small part of Mydei that hopes that a familiar taste will spur a quicker recovery, what with the progress that Anaxa had mentioned.

Phainon's house is situated on a quiet street near Marmoreal Palace, and it is quite humble in spite of the prestigious location. He had been keeping flowers before Okhema's fall, but they have wilted from neglect, the once colourful ceramic pots and window planters now dull and lifeless. It's yet another reminder of the state that Phainon has been in, but Mydei shakes the thought from his mind. He is not one to sink into despair, and he can't allow himself to anyways. Not right now, when he should be focusing on helping his beloved heal.

He fishes the spare keys out of his pocket and lets himself into Phainon's house, leading him to the living area and sitting him down on the sofa. He then sees that a thin layer of dust has covered mostly everything, but in spite of that, there are signs that the house has been lived in, like ghostly afterimages of the life that its occupant once led: his favourite blue goblet

on the dining table, a stack of neatly folded clothes that he had yet to pull away, an antique that he had been in the middle of appraising on his desk. Mydei decides that he'll help reorganize later, perhaps when Phainon is asleep. For now, he gets to work putting the ingredients he had just bought to good use.

From the bag of groceries, Mydei retrieves a sack of flour, sugar, eggs, goat milk, and fresh fruit—perfect for a batch of simple honeycakes. Within 20 minutes, the food is ready, and Mydei brings a plate back to Phainon, who hasn't moved from his spot.

"Phainon," he says, sitting beside him and placing the plate on the small table in front of him. "You need to keep your strength up."

Phainon's eyes flicker, and he looks down at the honeycakes. The fact that he reacted at all is promising, but he still makes no move to feed himself, so Mydei takes the fork and knife and begins cutting one of the honeycakes into bite-sized pieces. Then, he takes a piece and presses it to Phainon's lips.

"Eat," he says gently but firmly. Phainon's gaze moves back up, staring at Mydei for a few moments, but he accepts the piece, chewing slowly and swallowing without a problem. Hyacine had mentioned that Phainon was able to eat even before he started treatment, so this is nothing to be excited about, but in light of all the recent developments, Mydei can't help but feel like they're making progress.

It takes a while for Phainon to finish the honeycakes. Understandably, he eats rather slowly, but Mydei remains patient, feeding him small pieces until the plate is empty. Once he's done, Mydei puts the plate back down on the table, deciding to rest for a little while. He leans back against the sofa, his palms against the cushions as he stares blankly at the ceiling. Phainon still doesn't move, and the quiet between them grows.

Silence isn't uncommon between them. Mydei and Phainon share an understanding that transcends any spoken language, and sometimes, nothing needs to be said. Nevertheless, Phainon is usually the one who fills

the silence with his chatter, and though Mydei is more partial to peace and quiet, he finds himself missing the sound of Phainon’s voice.

Just as he had when he held back the black tide alone in Castrum Kremnos.

That endless battle had lasted for weeks and months on end, to the point where he could no longer tell the passing of time, to the point where his life in Okhema had begun to fade into distant memories. He hadn’t been naive enough to truly believe that they would reunite in some idyllic paradise beyond the sea of souls. But a not-insignificant part of him did yearn painfully for that promised next life, having resigned to the fact that the simple happiness that he and Phainon desired would not be possible to attain in this life.

Yet even after reuniting against all odds in this lifetime, that future *still* feels like it's slipping through his fingers like grains of sand.

Mydei closes his eyes, forcefully dispelling those thoughts for the second time that day.

If Phainon can’t speak, then Mydei will fill the void in his stead. That is the essence of their relationship: equal parts giving and taking, compensating for what the other lacks. Now and always, forever more.

“That cat-eared thief tried stealing a dress from Aglaea the other day, but she was caught in her golden threads,” Mydei begins absentmindedly. “I had thought Aglaea would be more cross, but instead, it seems like she was amused.”

No answer. Mydei continues.

“Now that her curse has been removed, Castorice has started keeping a garden. It seems like her flowers are growing well, thanks to Hyacine’s instruction. She mentioned wanting to ask you for your advice too, once you have recovered.”

Phainon remains silent and still, as if he hadn’t heard Mydei speaking at all. Mydei continues.

“That reminds me… You may not remember, but during one of our outings, Castorice and Hyacine were discussing a restaurant that they had recently been to. It seems like it specializes in desserts. Perhaps you would be interested in going…”

It goes on like this for some time, Mydei mentioning happenings within the Chrysos Heirs, their correspondence with the Astral Express, humorous incidents in the streets and the baths, and the latest gossip spreading around the World Wound Web. He hopes against hope that one of these topics will sound familiar enough, or perhaps outrageous enough, to prompt a reaction, but in the end, Phainon only responds with silence.

Mydei’s voice trails off. Even with those he’s close to, he’s not one for small talk—that’s more of Phainon’s forte—and keeping up such a one-sided conversation is a little draining. Admittedly, he’s also somewhat disappointed that Phainon hadn’t said anything, with how optimistic Anaxa had seemed about his recovery… But perhaps he should have expected this. After all, Anaxa also said that it would take some time for the results of the treatments to show, so maybe Mydei had been anticipating too much after only a handful of sessions.

He sighs softly, standing up and taking the plate as he does. “I’m going to go clean up. I’ll be right back.”

Resigned, he crosses the living area in a few quick strides, not expecting anything else. But just as he’s about to leave the room, he finally hears it—a familiar voice.

“...My…dei…”

Mydei nearly drops the plate.

His name had been spoken so softly that he fears that he imagined it. Almost *afraid* of that fear being realized, Mydei turns slowly, staring at Phainon in disbelief.

“...Phainon?”

Phainon doesn’t say anything at first. He’s not even looking at him, his head lowered, his dull, blue eyes unfocused. But sure enough, his lips move again, his voice hoarse from weeks of disuse and barely audible—but undoubtedly there.

“...Mydei…”

The dishes can wait. Mydei immediately moves back to Phainon’s side, placing the plate back on the table so he can touch his arm.

“Phainon,” Mydei breathes. “Can you hear me?”

Phainon doesn’t raise his head, but he seems to react to the sound of Mydei’s voice, the faintest spark of recognition brightening his eyes ever so slightly.

“...Mydei,” he says again, and Mydei nods, squeezing Phainon’s arm reassuringly.

“Yes… Yes, it’s me.” He resists the urge to laugh through his words, the relief nearly overwhelming him. “I’m right here, Phainon. I’m by your side.”

Jolted out of his despondence, his mind is now racing with thoughts. What should he say? What should he do? He had never expected to be the one to bear witness to such a monumental stage in Phainon’s recovery. In the back of his mind, he knows that he should immediately contact the other Chrysos Heirs, but there’s also a part of him that wants a few more moments of privacy with Phainon. There are so many things Mydei wants to say to him right now, so many things that *must* be said—so many that Mydei can’t single out what he *should* say first.

But to his surprise, it’s Phainon who continues speaking—

“...I’m…sorry…”

—whispering only those two words. And it’s enough to diminish the borderline celebratory mood that Mydei had been in.

“...I’m sorry… I’m sorry… I’m sorry…”

The apologies slip from Phainon’s lips, not because he is entirely cognizant, but because buried under the rage and hatred that had burned within him for eons, Mydei *knows* that there must have been a guilty conscience that haunted and tortured him for just as long. Perhaps the the words are murmured in reflex, spurred by the countless emotional scars that he had inflicted upon his own soul with every wound he carved into the bodies of his loved ones. To whom does he apologize? To Mydei himself? To the past Mydeis he killed with his own hands?

Or perhaps to the millions of his own past lives that he had assimilated into himself, burying every Phainon that came before, *being* buried by every Phainon that came after?

By all rights, Mydei should be horrified and betrayed that Phainon had been able to carry out such deeds so easily, so many times. Even in this cycle, the Flame Reaver—the 33,550,335th Phainon, carrying the burdens of the 33,550,334 who came before him—hadn’t hesitated to drive his sword into Mydei’s vertebrae, hadn’t even stopped to mourn for his beloved as he lay dying in a pool of his own blood.

But when he gazes upon Phainon and sees what it has reduced him to, that righteous anger dissipates like vapour before it can even form. All he can do is stare—

“I’m sorry… I’m sorry… I’m sorry…"

—trying not to come apart at the notion that the first words Phainon had spoken after losing nearly *everything* about himself—after recovering enough to finally, *finally* regain something for himself—were for an *apology.*

“Mydei… I’m…sorry—”

He’s heard enough.

Mydei pulls Phainon close to him, enveloping him in a tight embrace. With his face buried against Mydei’s shoulder, Phainon’s apologies finally cease. He feels slack in Mydei's arms, but the former crown prince can feel that he’s still awake, still at least *somewhat* aware, and that’s all that matters to him right now.

“...Then, on behalf of every Mydeimos that came before me,” he mutters into his ear, practically kissing it, “I forgive you.”

Would he have forgiven Phainon so easily had the situation been different? Had Phainon come out of his eternal trials more whole? Mydei doesn’t know. But he’s not one to dwell on the what-ifs, either.

All he cares about is ensuring that his beloved—the Phainon that's before him right now, the one and only man whom Mydei had sworn his life to—never gets hurt again.

“And for all the other Phainons that you erased…”

His hold on Phainon tightens.

“...I forgive you as well.”

Phainon’s fingers twitch.

Chapter End Notes

See? Don't worry! Be happy!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> I've noticed that every time I write a multi-chap fic, there will always be a Chapter. That Chapter will both be very hard for me to write and it will also make me question myself endlessly. Anyway, that's what this chapter was for me, which is why it took a little longer, and I'm still not sure if I like it... But I hope it's ok for readers at least?
>
> I was hoping to finish this fic before 3.5 came out but I don't think that's happening 😭 However, if the next chapter isn't the last one, the one after that definitely will be. Hopefully 3.5 doesn't get me too badly!

Phainon doesn’t speak again for the next few days.

Whether it’s because his momentary capacity for speech was a fluke or some other reason, Mydei doesn’t know. Even so, he doesn’t try to force him to try to talk. Phainon remains noticeably fatigued, tiring at the slightest exertion, despite the fact that he had previously wiped out an entire hoard of black tide creations without effort, and Mydei can only assume that it has to do with the damage done to his mind. Pure instinct does not require thought, but most other things in life do, so he doesn’t rush him.

It’s only when a week passes with no changes does Mydei think to consult Anaxa for his opinion on Phainon’s progress. The scholar spends a few moments considering the possibilities before answering.

“The fact that he was able to say anything at all is quite promising. Unfortunately, it’s too soon to conclude whether it was a happy accident or whether he’s actually making progress in his recovery, especially given that he hasn’t spoken again for almost an entire week.” Anaxa taps his chin in thought. “He said your name, yes? I surmise that he was able to recognize you were in the room with him and reacted accordingly. Of course, there’s also a possibility that he was simply calling for you out of habit.”

“Habit?” Mydei repeats.

“I don’t think anyone can understate how much Phainon talked about you,” Anaxa continues. “Among all the Chrysos Heirs, you’re probably the one who has made the strongest impression on him. It only follows, then, that memories of you would resurface before everything else.”

Mydei looks down, torn. He doesn’t like the thought of his and Phainon’s “conversation” having been a product of Phainon’s memories, rather than a sign of improvement in his cognition, but he’s admittedly partial to the idea of being that important to him.

“Incidentally…” Anaxa’s voice shakes him out of his reverie. “What else did Phainon say to you?”

The former crown prince pauses, remembering the tortured apologies that had been whispered to him in the room that day, and looks away.

“...Just my name. Nothing else,” he finally says.

Anaxa watches him quietly, and Mydei has the feeling that he doesn’t entirely believe him. But thankfully, the scholar seems to recognize the reasons behind Mydei’s lie and doesn’t press him for more details.

Phainon does begin showing marked signs of improvement as more time passes. His treatments seem to be working well, and with Mydei escorting him back home after his sessions, he’s able to take note of the changes. Phainon remains alert for longer periods of time, visibly reacting to what happens around him. On more than one occasion, Mydei has observed him watching dromases at rest and chimeras at play, and though he appears tired, his half-lidded eyes keenly follow the path of any of the butterfly-like nymphs that happen to flutter past his head. One day, when he sees Phainon staring at a batch of yellow flowers on display in a flower shop, he comes up with an idea, touching his arm gently to get his attention. Phainon turns his head, now looking at Mydei, as if waiting for him to say something.

He thinks back to what Hyacine had told him once, before they were about to depart the Grove after a session. “Lord Phainon is getting better, so you might be able to communicate with him now. If you talk to him, make sure your sentences are short and easy to understand. If you want to ask him something, try to keep it to things he can respond to with gestures or one-word answers,” she had said. They’re simple enough instructions to follow, but Mydei hadn’t found an opportunity to try it until now.

He points at the yellow flowers, making sure Phainon’s eyes can trace his index finger to the display. “Do you like those? Nod if yes.”

To his delight, Phainon nods.

“Do you want them?”

He nods again, and Mydei feels himself smiling. Though Phainon hadn’t been able to respond verbally, he was listening, and he had understood what he had asked him. It’s a start.

He purchases a few stems of the flowers, slipping them into one of Phainon’s hands. Then, he takes his free hand, leading him back to his home. Phainon lets go of neither the flowers nor Mydei the entire way back.

Finally, one week later, Phainon manages to speak again.

It’s such a mundane thing, but in these extraordinary circumstances, the chance to return to mundanity is one of the most welcome gifts of them all.

That’s why, when Mydei asks if Phainon wants to go on a walk together, and Phainon responds with a quiet “Yes,” Mydei is quick to spread the news to the others—but not before holding his beloved tightly.

The improvements only continue from there, and within another week, Phainon is beginning to answer Mydei more regularly, though his speech is often slow and punctuated by pauses, and only ever spoken in response to simple questions. He struggles with more complex sentences and never

initiates conversations, but Hyacine informs Mydei that this is to be expected from someone with his level of brain damage, and that his progress is something to celebrate nevertheless.

Eager to discuss the changes, Anaxa wastes no time in gathering the Chrysos Heirs for another meeting a few days after the good news. This time, the group consists of himself, Hyacine, Castorice, Aglaea, and, of course, Mydei.

“So, we have now confirmed, without a shadow of doubt, that Phainon is reacting to visual and auditory stimuli and understands simple questions. He also is capable of speech, but only in brief sentences.” Anaxa glances at Mydei. “Do I have that right?”

The Kremnoan nods. “That’s correct.”

“Then his recovery is proceeding smoothly, and at a much faster pace than I had initially hypothesized,” Anaxa announces to the other Chrysos Heirs. “But before we move onto phase three—the phase concerning any possible memory loss—we should first determine what Phainon *actually* remembers.”

“How do you suggest we do that?” Aglaea asks.

“We can gauge where he is by how well he recognizes us. It’s not the most reliable test, but it will be simple enough to perform, and it won’t exert him too much.” Anaxa’s one working eye drifts to a quiet corner in the room, where Phainon is currently seated on a comfortable armchair, holding Little Ica in his arms. “Just keep his mental state in mind, and don’t be too disappointed if he doesn’t remember who you are.”

Aglaea raises her eyebrows. “I believe everyone in this room was already prepared for that possibility, even without you highlighting it. Are you simply trying to reassure yourself, Anaxagoras?”

“What an absurd proposition. Why would I need to reassure myself?” Anaxa sniffs. “Now, if you’re all ready, let’s go speak to him. Try not to overwhelm him.”

Without waiting for the others to follow, Anaxa approaches Phainon first, calling out to him more gently. “Phainon.”

At the sound of Anaxa’s voice, Phainon raises his head and turns towards him, but he doesn’t say anything. Encouraged by the reaction nonetheless, Anaxa continues.

“Do you know who I am?”

Phainon spends some time staring at his former teacher blankly, and for a moment, it doesn’t seem like he’ll answer. But then, his lips move, allowing his barely audible voice to be heard.

“...Professor…Anaxa.”

“...Ha. Not entirely correct, but I’ll let it slide this time on the account of your condition.” Despite what he says, Anaxa’s words lack any bite—in fact, he seems more relieved than anything else. He steps aside for the other Chrysos Heirs, who are close behind him. “Can you tell me the names of everyone else gathered here?”

Phainon raises his head further, his half-lidded eyes slowly moving from one person to the other.

“...Miss Castorice. Hyacine. Aglaea…” His gaze falls on Mydei, and the former crown prince swears that he sees his eyes soften. “...Mydei.”

Trying to suppress their glee, Castorice and Hyacine throw their arms around one another and hug each other tightly, bright smiles on their faces. Reacting to Hyacine’s joy, Little Ica trills happily in Phainon’s arms. Aglaea is also smiling, having let out the breath she was holding. Satisfied with the results, Anaxa turns back to Phainon again.

“Now… Tell me your own name.”

Phainon pauses, as if having to deliberate on the answer. Then, he speaks slowly.

“Khaslana…of Aedes Elysiae,” he mumbles. His tone is dull, unenergetic, and expectedly, his speech is riddled by long pauses as he struggles to maintain a firm grasp on his words. “Phainon…warrior of…Okhema.”

Behind Anaxa, Hyacine and Castorice smile at each other again. Even Aglaea looks more pleased than usual—at least, until Phainon says what he does next:

“Lord Ravager…Irontomb.”

The hopeful mood diminishes immediately. Smiles fade, and Anaxa’s brow furrows. Startled by such an out-of-pocket answer, Mydei lips part to speak, his heart sinking, but as usual, it’s Aglaea who steps forward first, her voice stern and sharp.

“Anaxagoras, what is the meaning of this? Why is he introducing himself as the Lord Ravager?”

“Patience, woman. I’m trying to figure that out myself.” Anaxa turns back to Phainon, addressing him once more. “Tell me your name again.”

“...Khaslana. Phainon…” There’s another brief pause before he continues. “...Irontomb.”

Staring at Phainon for a little longer, Anaxa sighs, taking a step back. “...Well. We did manage to confirm that he does remember who we are, and that he maintains a sense of identity. In light of what he had done to himself millions of times, that’s a good sign…”

Mydei looks down, remembering the repeated apologies that Phainon had whispered in his torment not too long ago, but he doesn’t say anything. Anaxa has also fallen silent, considering his options before turning to face the others. “I’m going to contact the Astral Express. They’ll have more information on the Lord Ravagers than we do. Let’s adjourn this meeting for now.”

The gathered Chrysos Heirs are left to wait things out as Anaxa excuses himself to sort out this unexpected development. The silence feels heavier than usual, but Mydei doesn't need to be a mind reader to guess why. In no mood to converse with such a bitter taste left in his mouth, he simply stands beside the seated Phainon as usual, while Castorice kneels by the swordsman's other side to hold his hand. Luckily, Phainon doesn't seem to be completely aware of the effect he's had on the others, and with no one else actively addressing him, he has gone still and quiet, his mind having drifted off once again.

After what feels like an eternity, Anaxa returns to the room, a grim look on his face.

"I was able to reach Dan Heng," he says, already answering everyone's questions before they can even form. "He told me that during the restoration process, they were unable to completely decouple Phainon from Irontomb. That is to say, his soul—or rather, his *'code,'* as they called it—was so intertwined with the entity that doing so carried a very high risk of corrupting his existence and rendering him unable to be restored at all."

It's not something that Mydei wants to hear—the thought of Phainon being unable to exist without the thing that had caused all of them so much pain, that had caused *him* so much pain, that had used him and forced him to fight and endure beyond his limits until he was reduced to an empty shell, is difficult to stomach. Beside Phainon, Castorice looks up, looking equally upset. "What does that mean for Lord Phainon, then?" she asks, unable to conceal the apprehension in her voice.

"Nothing, from the sounds of it. It doesn't seem like there have been any negative side effects so far, even after he encountered the black tide. If anything, Phainon now carries Irontomb's power within him, and the entirety of it is at his disposal to use. Ideally, he would never be placed in any situation where he would have to resort to doing so." The sage sighs. "If he truly can't exist without Irontomb at this point in time, then there's nothing to be done about it. At any rate, I was assured that it's completely inert, and it's no longer a threat to anyone's safety, nor is it likely to interfere with Phainon's recovery, so we won't have to worry about that."

There’s a pregnant pause in the room before Anaxa continues, voicing the thought that no one else dares to. “Of course,” he says. “That is before we consider how it may affect his self-perception once he *does* begin regaining more awareness.”

Finding that notion unpleasant to dwell on, Mydei’s hand automatically moves to Phainon’s shoulder, squeezing it tightly. The swordsman looks up at him inquisitively, but doesn’t say anything.

In the end, Anaxa and Hyacine conclude that it would be best to proceed with Phainon’s treatment as planned. And slowly but surely, as the days pass, Phainon’s condition continues to improve. Mydei puts aside thoughts of the Lord Ravager within his beloved, instead focusing his energy into doing what he can to help him heal. With Okhema now fully restored, the Kremnoan has an abundance of free time, and he uses that time to continue escorting Phainon to and from the Grove, participating in Hyacine’s and Castorice’s planned excursions, and otherwise accompanying Phainon as he slowly recovers. Mydei has never considered himself much of a caretaker, but being able to provide these simple things for the swordsman does bring him comfort, and he can only hope that Phainon feels the same.

The day of another scheduled session comes. Mydei approaches Phainon, who’s sitting quietly at the edge of his bed, and touches the back of his hand.

“Phainon. Let’s go.”

Mydei ensures Phainon raises his head and makes eye contact with him before he takes his hand and pulls him to his feet. Then, as always, he leads him out of the house before locking the door behind him and begins the journey to the Grove.

He fully expects to pass the journey in silence—Mydei has, regrettably, gotten used to the quiet that had replaced Phainon’s constant chatter. But to his surprise, Phainon actually speaks today.

“Where…?”

The fact that he had asked at all isn't that startling; Phainon had already begun initiating conversations without prompting at home. But this is the first time he has spoken during an outing.

"We're going to the Grove. You have another scheduled treatment today," Mydei answers, then pauses, wondering if that was too hard to understand. He adds, "We're seeing Anaxagoras and Hyacine."

Phainon doesn't answer for a while, simply walking quietly behind Mydei. Then, he stops, and feeling the sudden resistance, Mydei stops too, turning around and staring at Phainon questioningly.

"...Phainon?" he asks. "What's wrong? Do you not want to go?"

Phainon looks down, his eyebrows furrowing, and Mydei can tell that he's trying to convey what he wants to say. The former crown prince remains patient, knowing that such things can't be rushed—they're still early, anyway, so they have time. After a while, Phainon seems to figure out how to string his words together, then starts speaking again.

"...Professor Anaxa…and Hyacine," he mumbles. "Lately… They're tired."

Mydei blinks. He supposes that much is to be expected. Hyacine has been juggling Phainon's treatments, her duties at the rebuilt Twilight Courtyard, her usual therapeutic services, and the various outings she has planned with Castorice, while Anaxa has been burning the midnight oil to juggle his research and ensure his alchemy has the intended restorative effect on Phainon's damaged soul. Both of them are known for their ability to disguise their fatigue, so for Phainon to take note of such subtleties is a sign that he's on the mend.

But why would he bring that up now?

Mydei doesn't need to ponder that for long.

"It's…because of me. It's my…fault."

The quiet remark has Mydei staring in stunned silence at Phainon as he continues.

“I’m…hurting them. Again and again.”

Again, Phainon is thinking of others more than himself, again, Phainon is *blaming himself for things outside of his control.* Mydei finally finds his voice amidst the budding ache in his chest. “...It would hurt them more to hear you say that,” he says with surety, and he knows it to be fact. But it doesn’t seem to convince Phainon, who looks torn.

“Why…?”

“Because you’re important to them. Because they care about you.”

“But I’m…the Flame Reaver. And I’m…Irontomb.”

Mydei goes silent, the possibility he had been hoping to deny—the possibility of Phainon remembering who he was, yet *forgetting* who he was, losing himself to all of his overlapping identities—rearing its ugly head.

“I’m…different now. After everything I’ve done… Can I still…stay here? With everyone?”

Stop it.

“Shouldn’t I…leave?”

No.

“I’m…” Phainon’s eyes quiver. “I’m hurting you too…Mydei. Like always —”

Feeling himself coming undone at that, Mydei abruptly grabs Phainon by upper arms, his grip tightening hard enough to bruise, the suddenness of the gesture shaking the hapless swordsman’s body. Phainon barely reacts to the pain or the jostling, perhaps because he doesn't yet have the mental capacity to perceive them, or perhaps because the sensation is so minute compared to the millions of coreflames that had burned him alive for far too many

eternities. Either way, Mydei's grasp doesn't loosen, for his emotions are currently what direct him.

"You will always… *always* be one of us," he whispers, his tone harsh with anguish at the thought that Phainon would even *think* of himself as anything less than a person when he bears a heart that is so painfully *human*— that he would even *think* of isolating himself, of *willfully* disappearing from Mydei's life when he had already been so close to losing him.

That's why he knows it needs to be said:

"No matter what you've turned yourself into, or what you've been forced to transform into… It doesn't change anything."

That's why he resolves to leave nothing important unsaid ever again.

"You will *always* be *our* Phainon. ***Always."***

He doesn't know whether his words actually get through. Phainon simply stares at Mydei, a vacant look in his eyes. Then, his expression slackens, and he looks down blankly. And when Mydei finally releases his arms and slowly takes his hand to lead him again, much gentler than before, Phainon no longer protests.

They pass the rest of the journey through Okhema in silence, and even when they board the dromas caravan waiting for them, neither of them say a word. Mydei still feels somewhat unsettled, but he's significantly calmer now, and the silence allows him to repeatedly turning over his and Phainon's conversation in his mind. It's made him recognize, belatedly, that all of them are essentially treating the former Deliverer without his consent, and though he can't imagine that Phainon would have *wanted* to remain in his vegetative state forever, unable to see, hear, or talk to anyone he loved again, it does bring other thoughts to mind—thoughts about what to do with their new future.

If he had known that the Flame-Chase Journey was a lie—if he had known the Trailblazer would arrive and free them all from Lygus' shackles—what

would he have chosen to do with his newfound freedom?

It's not something that even Mydei has considered for himself outside of hypothetical conversations with Phainon. Even in those discussions, he had rarely indulged the former Deliverer, hardly able to conceive of a future beyond his duties as Castrum Kremnos' heir apparent, and later, the demigod of Strife. Not in this lifetime, anyway.

But Phainon was a different story, eager to chatter on about the possibilities—and now that Mydei thinks about it, he realizes that the swordsman had been trying to give him some ideas of his own. "If I wasn't the Deliverer, maybe I'd be a wanderer, or a mercenary, traveling all over Amphoreus and seeing all there is to see," he had said in one of their conversations on the topic, his eyes sparkling with child-like wonder as he envisioned such a life. "Professor Anaxa praises my debate skills as well, so maybe I could even be a scholar. What do you think, Mydei? Can you imagine me as one of the Grove's intellectuals?"

He had turned and grinned at Mydei then, and his cheeky expression had filled Mydei with the urge to knock him down a few pegs. After that, their conversation devolved into their usual nonsensical bickering, and then a competition that had ultimately led to them both being scolded by Aglaea. In spite of that, Phainon had remained his usual cheerful and energetic self for the rest of the day, eventually inviting (dragging) Mydei to the baths as if nothing had happened.

When Mydei's eyes drift to Phainon now, sitting beside him in quiet despondence, his heart aches for what had once been, and what *could have* been had Phainon not sacrificed himself millions of times over—all for the faint hope that everyone *else* could finally live to see the dawn.

Mydei finds himself wondering whether Phainon had ever considered a place for himself in the future he suffered for.

No, he knows the answer to that already.

Rather, the better question is probably this: *When* Phainon had stopped seeing himself as part of the world he was trying so hard to save?

Mydei is already speaking before he realizes. “Phainon,” he says softly, watching him out of the corner of his eye. He waits until he sees Phainon raising his head and turning to him before continuing. “What is your wish?”

“Wish…” Phainon is quiet at first, but he answers relatively easily. “To fulfill…everyone’s wishes. And if I can't...” His gaze lowers. “Pass them on…to tomorrow.”

Mydei feels his fists clenching, his gauntlets digging into his palm. Had they met his bare skin, he’s certain they would have drawn blood.

Of course Phainon would say something like that. Of course *that* would be his first answer. Even after burning himself to ashes a million times over for the world, he still would not consider his own wants, but what truly hurts is how *automatic* the reply had been, as if there was no other possibility *but* for him to act as the receptacle of the wishes of other people. “I’m not talking about the *Deliverer’s* wishes,” he says a little more harshly than he intends to. “I’m talking about *yours.* What does *Phainon* want? What does *Khaslana* want?”

The white-haired man falls silent, a look of confusion spreading across his face. Cognizant of his own agitation, Mydei takes a deep breath to calm himself down before trying again. Then, he turns to face Phainon fully, reaching over to frame his face with both of his hands.

“If you truly wish to fulfill everyone else’s wishes,” Mydei speaks more gently this time, thumbing a stray lock of white hair away from Phainon’s cheek. “Then allow me to share what mine is.”

He leans forward until their foreheads are touching. Phainon doesn’t reciprocate as he usually does, but Mydei can tell that he’s still aware, still watching him, still listening. That’s all he needs.

“My wish…is to hear you speak of your own wants. To listen to what you desire from the bottom of your heart,” Mydei says. “So for the sake of that wish…will you tell me, Phainon?”

Phainon's eyes flicker, the change barely perceptible if not for the fact that their faces are so close, and Mydei knows he *understood.* Even so, he doesn't say anything for the longest time. Mydei fears he simply won't. Getting him to voice his true thoughts had been like pulling teeth even when he was mentally sound, let alone now, while he's so impaired. But Mydei holds onto the hope that he's gotten through to Phainon, and that hope is rewarded when his lips finally move in the faintest of whispers.

"I want…"

His voice trembles ever so slightly.

"...I want…to go home…"

He mouths his desire, as if even voicing into existence is the greatest of sins —even though the wish is so innocent in its simplicity, and a sentiment that Mydei has echoed many times throughout much of his own shattered childhood and his adult life.

"...You want to go back to Aedes Elysiae," Mydei says.

"Aedes Elysiae…" Phainon looks down—as far down as he can while Mydei still holds his face. "...I can't…remember."

Mydei's eyes widen slightly, staring at the swordsman in mild disbelief. "...Do you mean to say that you can't remember your homeland?"

Phainon falls silent, and the Kremnoan can't tell whether it's in confirmation or denial. Anything is possible with the mental damage he has suffered, but the thought that it has erased even the burning hatred that had arisen from an even more powerful love is almost inconceivable. Mydei doesn't want to believe that Phainon has lost even *that* part of himself, that core aspect of his being that had motivated him for so long.

"...You loved Aedes Elysiae," Mydei finally says after some deliberation, his mind drifting to all those times Phainon had come close to speaking of his homeland, yet held his tongue. He wishes he had prodded him more.

Then at least he'd have *some* description of it for Phainon now. "You never spoke of it…but you loved it."

"Loved…" Phainon mumbles the word, pausing, as if he needs to turn it over on his tongue. "I loved… Aedes Elysiae," he repeats. "The golden wheat fields… The vast sea… The people who lived there..."

So he remembers, then. That comes as a relief to Mydei. But strangely enough, Phainon doesn't seem to be comforted.

"So why…did I set it aflame…? Why did I kill everyone…over and over again…?"

…*Of course.*

Mydei's heart sinks when the dreadful realization hits him. The Flame Reaver had appeared in Aedes Elysiae, bringing the black tide with him—in this cycle, and many more before that. And Phainon would have memories of the bloodshed, as well as the conflagration that followed the disaster, all brought about by his own two hands.

You had no choice, he wants to say, but even as he turns the words over on his tongue, they sound insincere, like nothing more than lip service. He doesn't really know if it's the truth, besides, because the undeniable reality is that after living through Amphoreus' cycles millions upon millions of times, Phainon is now capable of killing his friends, family, and allies without hesitation.

As with before, Mydei doesn't feel any revulsion at the fact, for he knows that no Phainon would have ever made the decision to turn his blade on everything and everyone he loved lightly. He had possessed the willpower to carry through with his convictions, come what may, no matter what he had to do, completely alone and worn as thin as he may have been, and to Mydei, that is true strength.

But it does leave him with no words of comfort for Phainon. Even if the swordsman could understand what he was saying in its entirety, would Mydei even be able to provide him with solace?

In the end, all he can do is hold Phainon tightly. Where words fail him, action will not.

You won't have to stain your hands with blood again. You won't have to fight alone again.

He only hopes that their closeness will convey this much.

Phainon doesn't reciprocate, but he doesn't pull away either, allowing himself to be cradled in Mydei's arms until their caravan arrives at the Grove.

The session takes a little longer than usual today. When the door to Anaxa's lab finally opens, only Hyacine comes out. True to Phainon's words, she *does* look a little more tired than usual, but she greets those waiting outside —this time, Mydei, Cyrene, and Dan Heng—with her usual sweet smiles.

"You're all still here…except for Grayie and your other pink-haired friend. Did they wander off?" she asks Dan Heng, and he nods.

"March wanted to take a walk around the Grove, so Stelle just went with her. Sunday and I were going to reconvene with them after Phainon's treatment was over, but…it seems like it's not done yet? Did everything go smoothly?"

Mydei looks up. There's usually a slight delay before Phainon, Sunday, and Anaxa exit the lab; if Phainon isn't led outside by Anaxa, Mydei is allowed in to guide him out. This time, though, the door remains closed. Hyacine offers them both a helpless smile.

"I think Sunnie would be able to explain it better than me, but it seems like he encountered some difficulties when he used his tuning on Lord Phainon today. He and Professor Anaxa are discussing that right now," Hyacine replies, then turns to Mydei. "Professor Anaxa asked me to talk to you about that, actually… I couldn't help but notice you both seemed a bit down when you arrived. Did something happen between you two on the way here?"

“...Not necessarily,” Mydei says after a brief pause. “We had some… conversations.”

“Oh! Lord Phainon was able to hold multiple conversations with you? That’s good!” Hyacine tilts her head. “But they weren't exactly happy, were they?”

“We didn’t get into an argument, if that’s what you were wondering.” The former crown prince runs a hand through his messy golden hair, trying to figure out what to say. He is not particularly well-known for his eloquence, but in this case, he stalls not for a lack of words, but for indecision.

He doesn’t feel as if it’s his place to share what Phainon had whispered to him at his most vulnerable. But if he doesn’t voice Phainon’s wishes, who will?

“Well, Mydei? Would you like to share your thoughts with the rest of us?”

Jolted out of his deliberation, Mydei turns around at the sound of the new voice. Anaxa and Sunday had exited the lab while he was thinking, and Anaxa now scrutinizes him with crossed arms before adding, “The more we know about Phainon’s current state, the better.”

“His current state?” Mydei repeats, alarmed. “Did something happen after all?”

“It is not anything so drastic, Mr. Mydeimos,” Sunday replies, keeping his tone even. Hearing him speaking so calmly does provide Mydei with some reassurance. “We were able to complete the treatment as planned. However, Mr. Phainon exhibited some dissonance today. Typically, this arises due to negative emotions, and while it has since been alleviated, Miss Hyacine, Mr. Anaxagoras and I were somewhat puzzled about the cause.”

“...I see.” Mydei sighs. Now, even Cyrene and Dan Heng are staring at him, and he feels as if he’s been left with no choice. “For his sake,” he begins. “Will you swear that this conversation will not be spoken of beyond these walls?”

“Well, I don’t think any of us can guarantee that we won’t share what we hear with the other Chrysos Heirs, seeing as this *does* concern Phainon,” Anaxa answers. “But if you’re speaking of anyone outside of Aglaea’s inner circle, then I don’t believe there’s any need for concern.”

Fair enough. Maybe having others who know will be beneficial to Phainon too. As much as it pains him, Mydei is aware his own limits, and there will always be things that he is unable to provide, needs he will be unable to attend to—but if the others are aware of those needs, that won’t be an issue. Deeming the answer acceptable, Mydei tells everyone about the conversations he had with Phainon that morning—both before and after they boarded the dromas caravan—though he keeps it brief, leaving out some of the finer details for Phainon’s sake.

After letting the explanation settle in, Anaxa hums thoughtfully. “I see… As more of Phainon’s awareness returns, so, too, do the memories of the atrocities he had committed… It makes sense, although it seems like he doesn’t remember other things quite yet.” The scholar raises his head, eyeing Dan Heng. “You look like you have something you’d like to add, Dan Heng. Speak.”

A little startled that he had been called on, Dan Heng takes a moment to gather his thoughts before speaking. “I’m not sure if it helps at all, but I was just thinking… There’s a condition known as ‘mara’ where I come from. It’s a blight caused by the Aeon of Abundance, bestowing immortality upon those who have it… But the longer one lives, the more the ego erodes. This is because, over the course of an endless life, the mind collapses under the accumulation of memories. And the most vivid memories are, invariably, the ones with the strongest negative emotions associated with them, which is what eventually drives people to madness.”

“How awful…” Hyacine whispers. “Is there a cure for this condition?”

“No, not yet. That’s why I wasn’t sure whether my saying anything would help. And it’s not like Phainon has been afflicted by the Abundance either, so his condition is distinct to begin with,” Dan Heng replies. “It’s just that, when Mydei told us that Phainon could only remember his more sorrowful experiences, I couldn’t help but think about the mara-struck.”

Everyone in the room falls silent, ruminating. But then, a bright voice cuts through the hush.

“Well! Just knowing that they’re not the same means that there’s still hope for Phainon, right?”

They all turn to Cyrene, who had spoken for the first time since the gathering began. With everyone’s attention on her, she continues.

“If Phainon can only remember his saddest memories right now, then we just need to help him remember his happier ones,” she says. “Or better yet, help him make *new* memories—memories that shine brighter than anything else.”

“While that’s a logical suggestion and simple enough in theory, I’m quite curious about how you intend to put this into practice,” Anaxa remarks. “Where would we even start?”

“Oh, that’s easy.”

Cyrene smiles knowingly, glancing into the lab, where Phainon remains sitting quietly.

“For the warrior who bore the world on his shoulders for so long to finally be able to relieve his burdens in the place where it all began… Wouldn’t that be romantic?”

Understanding dawns on Mydei immediately. "You mean to say... We should bring him back home."

"Mmhm!"

She glances around at everyone in the room.

"So? How about we plan a trip to Aedes Elysiae?"

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> As I mentioned in the previous chapter, I wasn't able to get all of this fic done before 3.5, but a majority of it was already planned before the patch, so there won't be any spoilers for 3.5 in this chapter...or the rest of the chapters, for that matter.
>
> This chapter's gonna be a bit more light-hearted! After the last two I thought it'd be good to have a break from the angst 😂

“So to recount your idea for those who weren’t there,” Anaxa says a few days later, after the Chrysos Heirs, Stelle, and Dan Heng have all gathered in one of Marmoreal Palace’s conference rooms. “You believe that bringing Phainon back to Aedes Elysiae will help him recover. Is there basis behind your theory, Cyrene?” he asks.

“They say that home is where the heart is,” Cyrene replies easily. “And I was thinking, maybe Phainon just needs a little bit of help finding his heart again. What better way to do that than to bring him back to his beloved home?”

“Lord Phainon did love his home a lot,” Castorice concurs. “Even though he came to Okhema young, even though he always tried to smile for everyone… He carried the weight of his loss for so long.”

Hearing Castorice’s agreement, Anaxa turns to Stelle and Dan Heng. “How far along are you in Amphoreus’ restoration process?”

“We’re not directly involved,” Dan Heng says. “The ones who are are focusing more on the larger city-states first. But I don’t think they would be opposed to shifting their focus to Aedes Elysiae.”

“It’s taking quite a while, isn’t it?” Cipher remarks, and though her tone is nonchalant, she observes both Dan Heng and Stelle with sharp eyes. “I’ve

been around the block, and a lot of places are still in ruins, or worse, corrupted, even though it's been more than two months."

"Time passes faster within the simulation—within Amphoreus than it does outside of it. For those on the outside, it's only been a few days," Dan Heng explains. "Given how much damage Irontomb did, it may take a while longer to restore everything."

Cipher clicks her tongue, her tail twitching irritably. "What a pain…"

"That's quite the discrepancy indeed," Anaxa says pensively. "Not that it's of any consequence to us, seeing as none of us can leave Amphoreus at the moment. Let us turn our attention back to the most pressing matter: how quickly will your comrades be able to restore Aedes Elysiae?"

For the first time, Stelle speaks up. "Probably not as long as a place like Styxia or Janusopolis? Aedes Elysiae is pretty small. I bet it doesn't even take up that much space on the server. The only assets they'd have to load in are all the wheat stalks, the wheelbarrows, the houses, those windmills, the scarecrows, and maybe that weird boat that's always floating in the distance. Most of it is out of bounds, anyway. I can't even interact with the doors of the houses."

Dan Heng throws an exasperated look her way. "*What* are you talking about…?"

"...And why do *you* know about Aedes Elysiae?" Mydei asks, narrowing his eyes at Stelle. She looks away with a grimace and quickly waves her arms in front of her, knowing the folly of trying to get between him and Phainon.

"Don't look at me like that! It's really hard to explain. Blame Lygus."

While that's easy enough to do, unfortunately for Stelle, Lygus had been rendered non-functional after the final battle, leaving her as the only possible target for Mydei's ire. He continues staring a hole right through her until she tries to change the subject.

"Anyway, when's the trip?"

“Obviously, it will have to wait until Aedes Elysiae and the paths leading to it are completely restored.” Anaxa raises his head, looking pointedly at Aglaea. “And of course, we’ll need to secure the *esteemed* Lady Goldweaver’s approval for Phainon’s extended leave as well.”

Aglaea returns Anaxa’s look with a disdainful glance. “Phainon is free to come and go as he pleases. I have not imposed any restrictions on his movements. And even if I had, I would have no qualms about allowing him beyond the borders of Okhema and the Grove as long as such excursions would be able to help him recover.”

“But it’ll still take some time for Aedes Elysiae to be restored, right?” Tribbie pipes up. “Can we do anything for Snowy while we wait?”

“Just what you’ve been doing already—making sure he’s as comfortable as possible,” Hyacine says. “Now that he’s more aware, he’ll definitely be able to appreciate your efforts!”

“Okay! We’ll sing lots for him, then!”

Cyrene giggles at Tribbie’s enthusiasm. “Even without going back to Aedes Elysiae, it seems like Phainon’s going to be able to make lots of happy memories.” As the conversation continues, she looks up at Mydei, who hasn’t said anything since he had questioned Stelle about Aedes Elysiae, and adds, “Why don’t you do the honours of being part of his first ones?”

Mydei blinks, a little startled at the abrupt remark. “...Me?”

“Yes, you. You’re very special to him, you know,” she says with a wink. “Why don’t you go see him right now? Seeing us talk in such *hush-hush* tones is probably making him feel lonely.”

“...How about you?” he asks. “Were you not childhood friends with him? I’m sure he’d appreciate your presence as well.”

“That’s sweet of you to invite me, but won’t I just be third-wheeling the whole time?” Laughing at the face Mydei makes, she holds her hands behind her back coyly. “I’m preparing a little special something for him, but

I'll need Stelle's and March's help for that, so I'm going to be a bit busy for the next few days. I'm sure he won't mind—we'll have plenty of time to catch up afterwards."

Mydei glances over to where Phainon is currently standing facing away from the group. Though the other Chrysos Heirs are not making an effort to outright exclude him from the conversation, he definitely does look a little pitiful not being part of it at all, and the fact that he hasn't made an effort to join is another painful reminder that, in spite of all his improvements, he remains far from what he used to be.

Encouraged by the nod that Cyrene gives him, Mydei quietly excuses himself from the meeting and walks over to Phainon. At his approach, the swordsman raises his head and turns around. He's holding Little Ica again—it's a habit he seems to have developed since he began receiving treatment—and is absentmindedly stroking their mane, though he stops when Mydei nears, unable to focus on more than one thing at a time in his current state.

"Why don't we take a walk around Marmoreal Palace?" Mydei begins. Phainon stares at him, then glances past his shoulder. Some of the Chrysos Heirs have dispersed already, but others, like Aglaea and Anaxa, still linger, locked in a deep discussion. He looks back to Mydei questioningly, and the former crown prince understands what he's trying to ask.

"The meeting is over, and I have the rest of the afternoon off. Shall we take a walk together?" he asks again, just in case Phainon has forgotten—Hyacine had mentioned that things he has just been told or asked might slip from his mind easily, but that's to be expected with his current affliction. Phainon, at least, seems partial to the idea of a walk, and he nods more eagerly than usual. But before he can do anything else, they hear Hyacine's voice sound from the hall.

"Little Ica! Where are you?"

"Doot-doot!"

At her call, Little Ica rises from Phainon's arms and floats towards the hall. Phainon stares after them, but he makes no move to stop them. As Mydei watches, he realizes that the swordsman may have enjoyed petting the tiny pegasus but currently lacks the faculties to ask for more time with them.

"If you want Ica to stay, I'm sure Hyacine would allow it. I'll ask her, if you'd like."

Phainon shakes his head, letting his arms fall to his sides. Mydei doesn't seem that convinced, but then, the swordsman begins speaking.

"Ica…is rounder," he says slowly.

Quirking his eyebrow at such an out-of-pocket statement, Mydei glances back towards the door as Little Ica disappears behind it. Now that he thinks about it, they *are* quite rotund. "Yes. I've heard that they have quite the appetite."

"Appetite… That's good." The corners of Phainon's mouth twitch upwards. "Before, in the Vortex of Genesis… They were thinner. They stopped eating… Because Hyacine was gone."

The Vortex of Genesis?

Mydei stares at Phainon, a little puzzled. Based on what Stelle had shared with all of them, Phainon had been alone with Lygus until she had reached his side. At the end of the world, Mydei himself had sensed Hyacine's ascent into divinity, and he had seen her shimmering barriers guarding the panicked civilians of Okhema as he raced through the fallen holy city to help intercept the black tide and the Flame Reaver's assault. While it's possible that she had sent Little Ica away to keep them safe, Mydei believes it's more likely that they stayed with her until the very end.

What exactly is he remembering? Mydei makes a note to ask Stelle for clarification later on, and see if she can corroborate what Phainon had said.

"Do you want Ica to stay with you? You have one more chance to change your mind, or else you'll have to settle for my company alone," Mydei says.

Phainon shakes his head again, though he remains still, watching Mydei expectantly. Only when his eyes drift to one of Mydei's hands does the former crown prince realize that he's waiting for him to lead him, just as he has been for the past two months.

It stirs some feelings in his heart, though not all of them are necessarily good, because while he is happy to be someone whom Phainon can rely on, he does want him to be able to go back to being able to stand on his own two feet. Before his thoughts can take a turn for the worse, Mydei quiets them.

That's exactly what we're working towards.

To that end, he will continue supporting Phainon with whatever he needs. Guiding him around is at least easy, and he's gotten used to it by now, and it's not like he's opposed to being seen holding hands with Phainon anyway. So he indulges Phainon's silent request, taking his hand and gently leading him out of the conference room.

Unfortunately, Mydei quickly realizes that he's not the best when it comes to "making new memories." The walk through Marmoreal Palace isn't anything extraordinary, nor does it really differ from what they've been doing daily at this point. Of course, there are so many things other Mydei could have suggested if Phainon wasn't as damaged as he is, but he doubts contests of strength, speed, or wit are suitable for him right now.

He sighs internally, glancing Phainon's way. Normally, his boyfriend would shine in situations that require spontaneity, but as per the current norm, he is quiet—although, he does look particularly alert today, slowly looking around and taking in the sight of their surroundings. And as they pass by the baths on the way to the outside of Marmoreal Palace, Phainon pauses, staring.

It's then that Mydei realizes that it's been two months since Phainon had come to the baths. He has been making sure Phainon stays on top of personal hygiene and helps him whenever necessary, of course, but the fact that he hasn't been able to participate in one of the most well-known

aspects of Okheman culture must be saddening, especially given how eager he used to be to bathe with Mydei.

But…Phainon is slowly getting better. He's been able to walk through Marmoreal Market without issue, even at its busiest. Surely, a bath wouldn't hurt?

"Do you want to bathe here?" Mydei asks.

Phainon doesn't answer, though from the look on his face, he seems to be pondering the answer. His eyes drift from the cold baths to the hot baths, where they linger.

Mydei turns his head, following Phainon's gaze. "You want to take a hot bath?" His lips twitch into a crooked smirk as he remembers their competition here—it was the last one Mydei had participated in before leaving for Castrum Kremnos, so it remains particularly stark in his mind. "Are you sure? The last time we came here together, you were soundly thrashed by me."

He says as much mostly to see how Phainon reacts to the reminder. Phainon takes their rivalry very seriously, and Mydei has always taken great pleasure in riling him up, a sentiment that the swordsman reciprocates. Of course, Mydei already knows that it's too much to expect that he'll be able to stoke Phainon's competitive spirit with such a provocation, but there's a small part of him that hopes that he'll see *some* hint of the spark he used to have.

Instead, Phainon only stares at Mydei, bewildered.

"Thrashed…?" he repeats.

Mydei's smile fades a little. "During our hot bath competition," he says, trying to swallow the budding apprehension. "The one that you challenged me to."

"Hot bath competition…" Phainon looks down, thinking. But after a while, his eyebrows furrow. "...Can't remember." When he looks up again and sees the way Mydei's face falls, he adds, "...Sorry."

“...It’s fine,” Mydei replies, forcing himself to keep his tone light. “It was a while ago already.”

Phainon falls silent again, looking a little sullen now, and Mydei doesn’t have to be a mind reader to guess that he’s in no mood to bathe anymore. Feeling a stab of guilt that his comment had brought down the atmosphere, he contemplates, trying to figure out what to do next, before he hears a long and drawn-out groan.

“Ughhh. This is hard to watch.”

Mydei’s head snaps up at the voice, his head turning. Eventually, he spots the “culprit” in a shadowy corner: Cipher, who’s leaning against the wall with her arms crossed, an unimpressed look on her face.

“Little prince, you really don’t know how to have fun, do you?”

He doesn’t have a retort for that. She’s not exactly wrong. Hephaestion, Perdikkas, Ptolemy, Leonnius, and Peucesta had been steadfast friends who had introduced him to the warmth of companionship, but they hadn’t exactly had the time to indulge in pastimes when much of their time in the wild was spent foraging for food or fighting for their lives. It was only after he had come to Okhema where he had been able to partake in more frivolous activities. In that sense, Phainon was his first introduction to anything “fun.” Seeing his lowered gaze, Cipher sighs.

“Oh well. I guess I have to do everything around here, don’t I?” She trots over, her eyes on Phainon, and when she gets close enough, she leans closer, her arms crossed. “Hey there, Deliverer boy. Do you know who I am?”

“Miss Cipher,” Phainon replies almost immediately.

“Wow~ To think that Amphoreus’ almighty saviour would see fit to remember a lowly thief like me! I’m flattered.” Satisfied, she moves back. “You know what, I’m in a good mood now, so why don’t you let your elder show you what a *real* good time looks like?”

Mydei stares at her, perplexed. “What are you…?”

“Hush, little prince. Just follow me, okay?” She turns around and begins walking. When Mydei and Phainon don’t follow right away, she glances over her shoulder. “You coming?”

Not really sure what to expect but seeing no harm in playing along, Mydei makes eye contact with Phainon before gently pulling him after him.

As it turns out, Cipher’s definition of a “good time” is a shopping trip.

With Mydei acting as both the pack mule and the wallet.

Phainon is penniless as usual, but even if he wasn’t, Mydei would never dream of taking his money while he barely has any agency. Still, he can’t help but throw skeptical glances Cipher’s way as the bags hooked around his arms grow in number and weight—filled with things that either briefly catch Phainon’s attention or that Cipher shoves into Mydei’s hands and *insists* that Phainon was looking at—somewhat disgruntled at the fact that she hasn’t paid a dime since they stepped into Marmoreal Market. Unfortunately for him, the thief either doesn’t notice or is willfully ignoring him, prompting Mydei to eventually clear his throat.

“You intended for this to be a good time for Phainon,” he starts. “Yet I’ve yet to see you contribute at all.”

“What, are you unhappy with the arrangement?” Cipher flashes him a smug, fanged grin. “You *did* say you owed me, so why not just consider this the chance to finally pay me back?”

When she puts it like that, Mydei can’t exactly argue. He *had* said something along those lines a few weeks ago. As long as Phainon isn't the one being taken advantage of, then he has no issue, but some doubt about Cipher’s intentions remain, especially when many of the things that he’s paid for don’t fall under the category of things that Phainon might be interested in.

“...Is this really for Phainon?” he asks after letting the doubt fester for a little longer.

“Hmm? Who else would it be for?”

You, maybe? Mydei wants to say, but he holds his tongue, instead focusing on the matter at hand. “The shops that you have led us to are not ones that Phainon would regularly go to.”

“Yeah, that’s ‘cause Princess Homebody and little Hyacine were the ones having him tag along to these stores. But he wasn’t aware of anything back then, so it’s not like he could’ve picked anything he liked.” She turns, flashing a peace sign at Mydei. “Well? Am I a considerate senior or what? Actually, you don’t have to answer that—I already know.”

Oh.

Right. Cipher had been watching over Phainon, Castorice, and Hyacine since they began their outings, even before Mydei regularly began joining —and long before Phainon’s first session. Which means that she’s essentially giving him another chance to catch up on some of the many things that he had missed out on while he had been in his vegetative state.

With that realization sinking in, Mydei decides to silence the rest of his complaints, at least, until Cipher speaks again.

“And if he ends up not wanting any of the stuff you bought for him, I’m always happy to take it off his hands~”

And *there* was the ulterior motive.

He sighs, ready to pull Phainon along to continue following Cipher, but he feels a tug of resistance. Pausing, he glances at the swordsman, who is turned towards a small stall selling antique jewelry. The store owner’s eyes light up seeing Phainon’s attention on his wares, and he waves the three of them over. Phainon answers the beckons without letting go of Mydei’s hand, and Mydei doesn’t fight the pull, heading over with him. Cipher also follows along curiously.

“Huh. I don’t think they ever went to this one,” she murmurs to Mydei. The former crown prince raises his eyebrows, scanning over the jewelry on display. Phainon isn’t usually one for accessories, so Mydei can only guess that he was attracted to the aged appearance of most of the pieces.

“Lord Phainon! What a joy to see you up and about!” the owner says, then nods towards Cipher and Mydei as well. “Lady Cipher, Lord Mydei, it’s good to see you two as well. Is there anything my humble shop can provide you with today?”

Phainon doesn’t answer verbally, but his eyes travel between the jewelry on display, finally settling on a pair of link bracelets. The chains are divided into eight distinct segments, each section sporting a metal setting bearing seven different-coloured gemstones—a colour that matches each Chrysos Heir, Mydei notices. The eighth and final stone is a clear gem, shimmering pure white in the light of the sun. The jewels on their own would be eye-catching, but all together, they create a rather garish combination.

Unfortunately, Phainon remains fixated on the bracelet, and the storekeeper leaps on the opportunity.

“You have good eyes, Lord Phainon! Although I cannot tell you the origin of this pair of bracelets, I can assure you that it is crafted from the highest-quality ores and the finest of gemstones. Both pieces are completely genuine, authenticated by yours truly!”

As Phainon continues staring, Cipher elbows Mydei lightly, a smirk on her face. “You know what to do, little prince.”

Mydei groans softly—those bracelets really do look awfully gaudy—then moves forward to retrieve the jewelry from the display and holds them out for the owner. “We’ll take these two.”

“Much obliged, Lord Mydei!”

After exchanging the appropriate amount of balance coins for the twin bracelets and stepping some distance away from the shop, Mydei turns to Phainon and gently nudges them into his hands. However, Phainon only

stares at them blankly, and Mydei quickly realizes that he may need help putting them on. Taking one of the bracelets back, he undoes it, then slips it around Phainon's left wrist before clasping it back together. But when he tries to do the same with the other one, Phainon withdraws his right hand, raising his head and watching Mydei expectantly. Seeing Mydei's bewildered stare, Cipher rolls her eyes.

"Seems like he wants you to match with him, little prince."

At that, Mydei internally grimaces. The bracelet is exactly the kind of thing he'd expect Phainon to like, but it's too tacky for his own tastes, and it clashes terribly with the rest of his outfit, so he's not too keen on wearing it. His unwillingness shows in his hesitation, making a face as he looks at the piece of jewelry.

"Not going to put it on?" He can hear Cipher snickering behind him. "You'll make our poor little Deliverer boy so sad."

…But even without her *unhelpful* reminder, rejecting Phainon's request while he's like this wouldn't sit well with him. So in the end, Mydei gives in, pulling his gauntlet off and tucking it away, then clasping the remaining bracelet around his wrist. After he's done, he holds out his arm so Phainon can see.

"There," he says. "Satisfied?"

At first, Phainon doesn't say anything. But his mouth curls upwards in the beginnings of a small, faint smile, and it suddenly hits Mydei—how much he has missed seeing his beloved laughing without a care in the world.

The rest of the day passes without incident. With Amphoreus' day and night cycles restored, the sun naturally begins its gradual journey towards the horizon, and by the time the Action Hour draws to a close, the skies over Okhema are painted in orange hues.

In spite of his initial misgivings, Mydei deems it a productive day. Though Phainon has barely said a word and is now once again expressionless, his

eyes seem a little brighter than before. He doesn’t need to voice anything for Mydei to recognize that he enjoyed himself during their outing.

“Before we ascended to divinity, you and I would sometimes share meals at this time,” Mydei says absentmindedly, then turns to Phainon. “Shall we find somewhere to eat? Just like old times.”

He can’t immediately tell whether Phainon remembers their routine or not, but either way, he seems receptive to the idea and nods. Mydei smiles.

But of course, he can’t forget about Cipher. She’s the reason he had been able to see Phainon’s smile, after all.

“Would you like to come with us?” he asks, fully intending to pay for her share of the meal as an extra show of gratitude for her efforts today. But to his surprise, when he glances over his shoulder, he finds that Cipher is already gone.

The Chrysos Heirs receive very few updates about Aedes Elysiae’s restoration at first. In the meantime, on Anaxa’s and Hyacine’s request, Dan Heng retrieves the data bank's files on the mara and the many curative methods that the Xianzhou natives have attempted in the past. Although none of them had been successful on actual mara-struck individuals, Anaxa reasons that they’re worth trying on Phainon, who hasn’t actually been afflicted with the Abundance. His modified treatments continue for some time, and according to the Grove duo and Sunday, he responds quite well.

Finally, two Amphorean weeks later, Dan Heng returns with news from the outside, and the Chrysos Heirs gather in the conference room once more.

“Aedes Elysiae should be restored soon,” Dan Heng begins. “However, there’s one issue that we believed we shouldn’t keep from you.”

Aglaea nods. “I appreciate your transparency. Please do continue.”

“About the people who once lived there…” Dan Heng pauses, his brows furrowed, trying to best convey his message. “We were told that it would be

very difficult to restore them, since their data was corrupted by the black tide. It's not impossible, but it's not guaranteed either—and even if it was, it would take a much longer time than it will to restore Aedes Elysiae itself. The only way we could absolutely ensure that they all come back would be to start another cycle, but…"

He doesn't have to continue for the implication to sink in—that starting a new cycle would effectively kill everyone. A grave atmosphere settles over the room, broken only by a hum from Anaxa.

"It makes sense. Living people are far more complex than inanimate objects and vegetation," he muses.

"Yes… And the restoration process will be further complicated by the amount of time that's passed on Amphoreus. The only reason we were able to bring you all back to life more easily was because you had only died recently," Dan Heng says. "The same goes for everyone else who was restored."

Mydei lowers his head slightly, a stormy look in his eyes. He had been wanting to inquire about Hephaestion and his other companions, perhaps even his mother, but hearing the news, he decides to put the thought aside for now.

"Hmm… But as long as we have Aedes Elysiae itself, that's a start, right?" Cyrene pipes up. "I'm sure just seeing the environment will help Phainon a lot."

"Hold on. Going home to a desolate village may do him more harm than good," Anaxa says, his voice stern. "I'm sure I speak for mostly everyone when I say that people make up at least half the memories of a home. If Phainon returns to Aedes Elysiae only to find it devoid of his friends and family, it may only remind him more of what he's lost."

"But it won't be devoid of his friends and family," Cyrene replies, glancing around the room at everyone else. "Because we'll all be there with him. Won't we?"

It doesn’t take too long for her subtle suggestion to sink in. Tribbie is the one who lights up first.

“That’s true! Snowy won’t have time to feel lonely if we make it fun for him,” she says. “That’s part of what it means to make good memories with him, right?”

“You got it, Tribbie!”

“...Hm. That’s a reasonable enough idea, I suppose.” Anaxa nods, then glances down at Hyacine, who has been quietly standing beside him, a thoughtful look on her face. “Hyacine. Is there anything you want to add?”

“Oh, I was just thinking…” Hyacine raises her head to look at Anaxa. “One of the things that tormented Lord Phainon for so long was his inability to save anyone… That’s what he mentioned during his debate with the Council of Elders at Dawncloud, yes?”

“That’s correct. Specifically, he was forced to kill all of his kin, who had been turned into black tide monsters.”

Hyacine looks saddened at that, but quickly forces her pained expression down. “And as the Flame Reaver, he brought the black tide to Aedes Elysiae himself millions of times… With so many memories of him killing his loved ones with his own two hands, it’s no wonder he’s struggling so much.”

“But those are all things that we already know. What are you suggesting, Hyacine?”

Hyacine turns to regard everyone in the room. “Our original intention was to take Lord Phainon to Aedes Elysiae to help him heal in a place he loved. But what if we reframed it as some sort of…task for him?”

“A task?” Mydei asks. “What do you mean?”

“From what I can tell, Lord Phainon bases a lot of his own worth on what he can do for other people,” Hyacine continues. “It may seem

counterintuitive to put him to work while he's still recovering, but it'll be more difficult trying to help him adjust his mindset with the state he's currently in… So I thought we could try playing into it instead."

"Now that you mention it, Sunday did say that Phainon occasionally shows some resistance to his tuning," Dan Heng says. "He said that while he's no mind reader, he can feel faint hints of certain sentiments within Phainon… Things like guilt and unworthiness—like he doesn't deserve the care he's getting. They seem to be the cause of most of his 'dissonance.'"

"Right, Sunnie mentioned that to me and Professor Anaxa as well," Hyacine says with a nod, then quickly continues speaking before Anaxa can correct her on his name. "That's why, I think giving him a task would help him take the first step to overcoming those feelings."

"You still haven't mentioned what this task you're thinking of is," Anaxa says pointedly.

Hyacine smiles. "What if we had Lord Phainon participating directly in Aedes Elysiae's restoration efforts himself?"

The room once again falls silent, pondering the abrupt suggestion. It's Cyrene who speaks up first, her eyes bright with comprehension.

"Ohh, I get it!" she says gleefully. "You're so smart, Hyacine!"

"Ehehe… I'm glad you think so, Renie."

Anaxa is the next to voice his understanding. "Hmm… Yes, I can see where you're going with this. This may also be helpful in addressing the ongoing issue of his self-perception…especially regarding his identities as both the Flame Reaver and a Lord Ravager."

Hyacine nods again. "If we can show him that destruction isn't the only thing he's capable of, I feel like it'd help him a lot!" She turns to Dan Heng. "But that does mean we can't restore Aedes Elysiae completely. Is it possible to remove the black tide's corruption but leave some things broken that we can fix? Not so much that the entire village is still in ruins, but

enough so that we'll all have something to do, to show Lord Phainon that we're all there with him and helping him."

Dan Heng doesn't answer right away, raising a hand to his chin in thought before nodding as well. "I think it's doable. I'm not sure how it'd work, but I can't see it being a particularly difficult task for the Genius Society. I'll raise the idea with them. They should be open to it."

Hyacine beams. "Great!"

With her hands at her mouth, Cyrene giggles happily. "I can tell that this will be a really good trip. I'm getting excited already!"

Feeling similarly hopeful sentiments, Mydei nods in silent agreement. And as the room becomes awash in the murmurs of trip planning, he glances over at Phainon, who has been standing quietly at the window the entire time, staring at the sky. Sensing Mydei's eyes on him, Phainon turns around, tilting his head curiously.

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> March/Evernight is mentioned in this chapter, but I'm not really sure what's going on with her so I kept it mostly vague. I didn't want to exclude her though, because I really like the Traiblazer/Dan Heng/March/Sunday quartet, so I'm pushing my agenda... That said, nothing else is based on anything that was revealed in 3.5, as I had these ideas before the version update.
>
> I found this chapter hard to write, so as a result, I'm not that confident in it 😔 But hopefully, it's at least enjoyable for readers!

A week later, the Chrysos Heirs receive word that Aedes Elysiae has been restored, and they disperse into smaller groups as the date of the trip steadily crawls closer. One chamber in Marmoreal Palace is bustling with activity as Tribbie, Trianne, and Trinnon begin packing for the journey.

“Teleslate, check! Photostone, check! Hm… Are we forgetting anything?” Tribbie hums, looking up at Aglaea, who is seated at her favourite table during a rare moment of leisure. “Agy, have you packed yet?”

“I have. And yourself, teacher?”

“Mmhm! We’re double- and triple-checking all of our bags so we don’t forget anything! Make sure you do the same!”

“I will. …Ah. You just reminded me. There is one matter of great importance I must attend to—and certainly one that I absolutely cannot forget.”

Tribbie tilts her head. “What is it, Agy?”

Aglaea turns to the shadows. “Cifera,” she calls softly. “I know you’re there. You cannot hide from the golden threads.”

The figure concealed in the darkness stiffens for a split second before sighing. Cipher emerges, her arms raised in a headrest—the very picture of nonchalance. “Spoilsport. Why do you keep those things up, anyway? It’s not like the Council of Elders is any threat these days.”

“Be that as it may, we still live in tumultuous times. For the sake of those who are still nursing their wounds, I cannot let my guard down.” Her eyes soften. “But that is not what I wish to discuss with you.”

“Well?” Cipher yawns and stretches. “Out with it, then.”

“Will you be coming with us to Aedes Elysiae?”

Still partially turned away, Cipher pauses mid-stretch. “Huh? Was I actually invited?”

“Anyone is free to come. I’m sure after all the help you have provided him from behind the scenes, Phainon would be pleased to see you there,” Aglaea replies, not overtly acknowledging the way Cipher tenses for a moment. “But to answer your question, I did want to specifically extend an invitation to you.”

“Hmm~” The thief hums, her tail swishing languidly. “You sure about that? Setting a street cat loose in an empty village… You may as well be asking for all of Aedes Elysiae to get looted!”

“If that is the price I must pay for you to accompany us, then so be it. I will be sure to reimburse Phainon and the rest of the villagers for their stolen belongings.”

Cipher blinks, her mouth ajar in surprise at Aglaea’s complete lack of hesitation. She watches the Goldweaver’s unchanging expression, as if trying to search for any sign of deception. When she doesn’t find any, she quickly slips back into her indifferent facade and shrugs.

“Ahhh well. How can I refuse such a *generous* opportunity?” she says with a snicker, then turns around with a nonchalant wave of her hand. “Fine.

Since you can't *bear* to be without me for even a second, I'll be there when the time comes. But don't come looking for me until then!"

Having silently watched the exchange, Tribbie giggles as Cipher disappears into the shadows once again, taking note of the genuine smile spreading across her face as she does. "Ciphy is as dishonest with her feelings as ever."

Aglaea smiles too, her sightless eyes lingering on the spot Cipher once stood. "She is… But I'm pleased that in these thousand years we've spent apart, she hasn't changed."

"Professor Anaxa, we're—oh…!"

Hyacine nearly trips over a stack of books, but luckily, she's steadied by Little Ica. Thanking her little companion, she glances around Anaxa's office, dismayed at the mess. With tools, stray manuscripts, and opened storage boxes strewn all over the place, it looks like a freak squall had torn the room apart. "Goodness… What happened? It looks like a storm passed through here!"

Anaxa's head pokes up from behind his desk, his hair and clothes disheveled. "There you are, Hyacine. I was looking for one of my scrolls for the trip. Also, call me Anaxagoras."

"Did that really require overturning your entire office…?" Hyacine pauses. "Wait, did you say 'the trip?' You're coming to Aedes Elysiae with us?"

"Yes…? Of course I am. Why wouldn't I?"

"Erm… Aedes Elysiae sounds like it's a little out of the way. The journey won't be too hard on you?"

"Nonsense. Will we not be traveling there by dromas? Steeds of such gentle temperament will make for a smooth voyage." Anaxa's one good eye gleams with glee as he grins. "Not to mention… Once we arrive, the dromases will be able to frolic in the open fields. I rarely have the chance to

see them outside of their enclosures… I am keen to observe how their behaviour changes with so much land around them."

Hyacine exchanges a glance with Little Ica. "Same old Professor Anaxa," she says with an exasperated smile. "But…even if you say that, you're worried about Lord Phainon too, aren't you? Or rather… You want to make sure you're close to him just in case he relapses, or something else happens. Right?"

Anaxa doesn't say anything at first, quietly bundling some scrolls together and slowly slipping them into the sack that lays open at his feet. "I won't deny that that's part of the reason."

"Hehe… Since we're going to the countryside, make sure you relax too, professor. You've been working harder than all of us to make sure Lord Phainon gets better."

"Not quite true. You've contributed greatly as well, Hyacine," Anaxa replies matter-of-factly, finally turning to face Hyacine. "In fact, I am confident when I say that Phainon would not have made as much progress as he did without your therapeutic treatments or the recreational activities you have been planning for him."

Hyacine's smile warms. "In that case, I hope this trip is fruitful for all of us!"

"Indeed."

When Mydei and Phainon embark, the sun has only begun to rise over Okhema. Though the streets are quiet and empty, and there's no chance of Phainon getting separated, Mydei leads him by the hand as usual. His new bracelet catches the limited light, sparkling in all colours of the rainbow; its twin is currently secured around Mydei's belt. His excuse is that he always wants to remain battle-ready and that jewelry makes a poor substitute for his gauntlets, but the arrangement *does* also spare him the sight of the awful, gaudy thing. Luckily, Phainon doesn't seem to mind as long as he's wearing it somewhere on his person and he makes no protest.

They walk in silence until they come across the corner where Castorice arranged to meet up with them. She's already waiting there when Mydei and Phainon approach, and upon seeing them, she waves to them before jogging over.

"Lord Mydei." She smiles up at him, hesitating, but when Mydei lets go of Phainon's hand and opens his arms for her, she eagerly hugs him. Once she's satisfied, she lets go and turns to Phainon. "Lord Phainon."

"Miss Castorice. Good morning," Phainon says, and though there's no smile visible on his face, it can be heard in his voice. "Nice to see you."

Castorice's visage brightens. She, like many of the others, has been religiously keeping up to date with Phainon's progress and is well aware that he's been improving, but she's happy to see that he's speaking more nonetheless. "It's nice to see you too, Lord Phainon. May I embrace you as well, to commemorate our meeting today?"

Phainon tilts his head, not really understanding her question. But knowing his boyfriend would never protest to a hug from Castorice, Mydei speaks up. "Go ahead, Castorice."

Encouraged by Mydei, for she can trust that he will always put Phainon's comfort above everything else, Castorice hugs Phainon tightly. The former Deliverer stiffens a little in surprise, but he slowly relaxes, loosely putting his arms around her. He can't seem to hold on too tightly, but Castorice doesn't look like she minds.

"'...You're warm,'" Castorice murmurs, lingering for a little longer. "'As warm as I imagined you to be.' I wanted to say these words to you before, but you could not hear me… So I'm happy I have the chance to tell you now." She looks up. "I can only hope that I can offer you the same warmth as well, Lord Phainon."

Phainon blinks, a little confused, before nodding. "Miss Castorice. Is warm," he agrees, and Castorice practically beams. Witnessing the both of them in such high spirits, Mydei can't help but smile as they all make their

way to the designated meeting place, where the other Chrysos Heirs and the Trailblazers are waiting.

The trip to Aedes Elysiae is slow and uneventful, but Mydei supposes that that's for the best. With the pleasant weather and the gentle gait of the dromases, the journey is surprisingly relaxing. Beside him, Phainon has been lulled to sleep by the rhythmic movement of their steed, his head on Mydei's shoulder. Around them, snippets of the conversations that the others are having drift by his ears.

"Ah, Professor Anaxa, don't lean so far over the saddle! You can observe the dromases when we get to Aedes Elysiae!"

"Leave him, Hyacinthia. If he falls and cracks his skull, that would leave me with one less headache to deal with."

"Oh? Still so eager to get rid of me, Lady Goldweaver? Why not finish the deed yourself, then?"

"Sunday, are you okay? You look so tense…"

"...I'm fine, Mr. Dan Heng. It's just that Miss Cipher has been staring at me quite intently. I'm not sure why…"

"I mean… Name a cat that *wouldn't* pounce on a bird."

"Stelle…"

"Are you taking pictures already, Cas? We haven't even gotten there yet!"

"But traveling with everyone like this is so fun… Lady March… Lady Evernight? She suggested that I take many pictures to preserve these memories."

"Oh! Trianne remembers Cas saying that she didn't have any pictures of her friends before. These can be your first ones!"

"Yes. These are fitting first photos, aren't they?"

“You should make an album with all of the pictures later.”

“Ohh, good idea, Trinnon! Trianne wants to see the album too!”

“Hee hee… I’ll show you when I make it.”

It’s like a scene out of a pleasant dream, or maybe a happy fairytale. Banter between comrades and friends, laughter shared beneath the warm sun… Months ago, Mydei would have deemed this kind of future unattainable in this life. He never wants to grow too complacent, because peaceful days tend not to last for him, but he supposes there’s no harm in basking in the moment for now.

Some time passes before he feels Phainon stirring again, and as he rouses, he raises himself from Mydei’s side. Blinking the sleep away from his eyes, he seems to realize quickly that he’s not in a familiar environment and looks around, but relaxes immediately upon seeing Mydei watching him.

“Did you sleep well?” Mydei asks.

Phainon nods, then begins looking around again. “Where are we?”

Mydei had already told him of the excursion beforehand, but he knows Phainon still struggles to retain information in his damaged state, so he remains patient. “We’re going on a trip.”

“To where…?”

“You’ll see,” he says, repeating the answer he gave him that morning, and when he notices that the green of the meadows they’ve been passing by is slowly metamorphosing into the gold of wheat stalks, he smiles. “You’ll see very soon.”

Curiously, Phainon turns his head to follow Mydei’s gaze, and when he, too, sees the vast expanse of wheat fields in the distance, his eyes slowly widen. Seeing the gold reflected in his eyes, Mydei knows that Phainon recognizes exactly where he is.

The dromases slow to a stop, allowing their riders to disembark. Mydei gets off first to help Phainon down from the saddle, and together, they join the others. As the sight of the idyllic landscape spreads before them uninterrupted and the sweet scent of wheat permeates the warm breeze, Phainon falls completely still, as if in disbelief at what he perceives. The Chrysos Heirs and Trailblazers pause behind him, waiting, allowing him a moment to take everything in.

Then, Cyrene brushes past him, turning on her heel to face the group, her hands behind her back, her silhouette framed in gold.

“Welcome to Aedes Elysiae,” she says with a bright smile as her eyes drift over to Phainon. “Or, I guess I should say…

“Welcome home, Phainon.”

Without needing Mydei to lead him, Phainon takes a slow step forward. Then another. Then another, until he’s walked past Cyrene. He eventually reaches the apex of a small knoll overlooking the entire village, the emotions that he’s unable to show on his face visible in his eyes, still wide and staring, and in the way his knees nearly buckle under the weight of what he must be feeling. Mydei is at his side in an instant, steadying him with a firm but gentle grip on his arm—to make sure he doesn’t fall, but also to ground him, to remind him that this isn’t a dream, but reality.

He watches Phainon’s eyes move slowly around the wheat fields and the beaten paths, the broken carts and worn scarecrows and houses and sheds, all in varying states of disrepair, but not unsalvageable. When the remnants of life register, he seems to notice that the entire village is abandoned and, confused, he turns back to the others.

“Where is…everyone?”

Cyrene smiles knowingly as she walks up to his side, watching the tranquil fields. “They’re all very far away right now,” she says. “But don’t worry. They’re making their way back as we speak. It may take them some time to complete the journey… Maybe a really, really long time. But eventually, they’ll come home, just like you did.”

“Mom and Dad too?”

“Mmhm.”

“And Livia… And Piso… And Galba… And Ms. Pythias?”

“Everyone.” Cyrene allows a moment for it all to sink in before she continues. “But you know, no one has lived here for a while, so everything looks a little beaten up—and that’s no state to be in for a happy homecoming!” She looks up at him. “Since we got here first, why don’t we try fixing up what we can? That way, when everyone comes back, the village will be all ready for them! What do you think, Phainon?”

Phainon stares at her, almost as if unsure. “I…can help?”

“Of course you can! You and I both know our hometown the best, don’t we? It’ll be a lot of work for just the two of us...but luckily, we’ll have a lot of helping hands.” She leans to the side, peeking around Phainon at the group behind them. “Right, everyone?”

Phainon turns to regard the others as well, the uncertainty still in his eyes, but all he receives in return are smiles and nods—all affirming their willingness to lend a hand to him. Mydei raises his head, meeting Phainon’s gaze with his own.

“Where should we start?” he asks. Realizing he and the others have placed the reins in his hands and are waiting for his direction, Phainon turns back to the village, thinking.

“...The houses,” he finally says, his demeanor more confident than before. “So everyone can have a place, to call home again.”

Seeing Phainon willingly take the lead, the Chrysos Heirs and Trailblazers exchange smiles and get to work.

The once-dormant village soon comes alive with bustling activity, the sounds of hammering and sawing, and friendly chatter.

Unsurprisingly, repairing Aedes Elysiae is a time-consuming and laborious job, but working together, they make quick progress. It would be impossible for ordinary people to restore so many dwellings to working order within just the span of a day, but the Chrysos Heirs are hardly ordinary people—Cipher zips to and from Okhema, bringing whatever materials they can't harvest from the nearby woods; Aglaea weaves her golden threads to act as scaffolding and temporary framework, and her Garmentmakers maneuver building materials into place with the direction of Tribbie, Trianne, and Trinnon; and Anaxa uses his alchemy to create miracles, restoring fixtures and structures that are beyond repair. Hyacine and Sunday remain on standby to tend to any bumps and scrapes that the others may acquire as they work, leaving Mydei, Phainon, Stelle, and Dan Heng to cover the manual labour—or so he had thought, until Castorice stuns everyone into silence by easily lifting a comically tall tower of wooden beams into her arms and carrying them to where they need to be.

"Well, she *is* one half of a Titan," Anaxa reasons amidst the dumbstruck staring. "It shouldn't be surprising."

With Castorice happily taking over his tasks, Mydei finally has a chance to take a breather. He notices Stelle resting beneath the shade of a tree, wiping the sweat from her brow, and walks over.

"You didn't have to come," he says, "But thank you."

After all, it had been made clear to the Nameless that they were not obligated to accompany the Chrysos Heirs to Aedes Elysiae—they had already aided enough in Phainon's recovery, along with the rest of Amphoreus' restoration, all beyond the realm of normal altruism, and most of the Chrysos Heirs agreed it would be unfair to ask them for more. Still, Stelle and the others had insisted on coming along anyway, claiming that

doing so aligned with their definition of “Trailblazing,” but what sticks out in Mydei’s mind is the way Phainon had lit up upon seeing Stelle waiting with the others.

“Wow, you’re so polite now. Such a far cry from what you were like when we first met,” Stelle replies with a cheeky grin.

Mydei laughs through his nose, remembering those simpler times with fondness. “I had no means with which to appraise you back then. But you and your comrades have proven yourself time and time again to be strong and virtuous. You are worthy of respect.” He pauses, noticing a distinct lack of pink-haired girls by Stelle’s side. “By the way, where are Cyrene and your other friend?”

He’s still unsure as to whether that other pink-haired girl is called “March” or “Evernight”—he’s heard her being referred to as both names. Stelle doesn’t provide any clarification on that matter, simply shrugging. “I have no idea. They slipped away somewhere while we were working. Maybe they’re checking on the fairies in the Membrance Maze…or maybe they’re slacking off? I wouldn’t be surprised.” She looks up at Mydei. “How about Phainon? Where is he? It’s weird not seeing him with you.”

Now that she’s brought that to his attention, Mydei glances towards village square, and true enough, he doesn’t see Phainon there, even though he’d stick out like a sore thumb among the scenery with his garb. But before he can answer, Sunday and Hyacine approach, the latter speaking up.

“If you’re looking for Lord Phainon, he’s in the fields surrounding Aedes Elysiae. Professor Anaxa is teaching him how to apply alchemic wards that will protect the village even after we leave,” she explains.

“Wards?” Mydei quirks an eyebrow. “I know nothing of alchemy as a craft, but I would assume setting up wards would require some level of expertise?”

“Ehehe… That’s what I thought too. But it seems like Professor Anaxa accounted for that.” Hyacine’s eyes twinkle. “I was wondering why he packed so many scrolls when we wouldn’t be here for more than a few

days, but then I realized that he probably wrote some equations on them to help make the wards easier to apply, even for someone who doesn't have any knowledge of alchemy or…"

Or someone with impaired cognition, goes unsaid, but she doesn't need to voice that for the rest of them to understand.

"I'm quite pleased to see that Mr. Phainon hasn't shown any signs of distress," Sunday adds. "Mr. Anaxagoras requested that I keep an eye on him just in case being in Aedes Elysiae triggers a resurgence of negative emotions or memories, but he seems to be doing fine. I can only conclude that Miss Hyacine's idea of having him participate in the village's restoration efforts must be helping him."

Hyacine lets out a small sigh. "That's good to hear. I knew we would be taking a bit of a risk bringing him out here, but it looks like things are turning out well."

Mydei and Stelle exchange relieved smiles. Then, a fifth voice interrupts them as Trianne flutters overhead.

"Heyyy! There you are!" she calls. "Come join us! We're all taking a break to eat!"

Eager to check in with the others, the four answer Trianne's beckons, following her as she leads them back to the heart of Aedes Elysiae.

By the time they reach the center of the village, a small cooking pot and an open fire have already been set up, and the others have gathered around. Mydei had assumed that they were going to share some of the food that they had packed for the journey, but instead, what he finds is a pile of freshly caught fish, with Dan Heng standing right behind it. Stelle lets out a low whistle when she sees the sight. "Wow. Where'd you get all of that?"

"Dan Heng caught them all," Aglaea explains. Behind her, Cipher is practically drooling as she stares ravenously at the fish. "Thanks to him, we

will not have to draw from our supplies, although we were not lacking in them to begin with."

"Wait… But did we even pack fishing rods? How'd he catch so many?"

Dan Heng opens his mouth, but it's then that March (Evernight?) makes her presence known from behind him. "He decided to take a swim in the lake," she says with a wily smile, making him start. "It seems like the water temperature was just right for him."

The Archivist clears his throat loudly and turns his head away, looking a little embarrassed for some reason. "...We'll need to cook all of it, though."

At that, everyone turns to Mydei, staring at him imploringly. Sighing, but having anticipated it, he steps forward.

"Fine," he grunts, removing his gauntlets. "But all of you will help me gut and clean them. We'll complete the preparations more quickly that way."

For a taste of Mydei's cooking, everyone happily obliges, and soon, the village square is filled with the sound of sizzling and the fragrance of lightly seasoned grilled fish.

Unexpectedly, the comfortable atmosphere throws him back to a much more different time and place, yet one that was similarly filled with laughter and camaraderie. He had shared many a moment like this during that decade he spent wandering the wilds, and though those times had been far more uncertain and fraught with perils, he had never once feared for the future, for he knew he would always have his most trusted friends at his back.

No one will ever be able to replace Hephaestion, Perdikkas, Leonnius, Peucesta, and Ptolemy in his mind, but the Chrysos Heirs are his companions all the same, and their presence does mend the scars that those five had left behind.

Speaking of companions…

Noticing that Phainon is suspiciously absent, Mydei looks around the square, searching until he finds him sitting a short distance away from the group. As he recovered more, he had developed a tendency to separate himself from the others when given the opportunity, Mydei has noticed, but he doesn’t know whether it’s a product of him sitting through numerous meetings that he hadn’t been able to participate in or whether it’s out of lingering guilt from his memories as the Flame Reaver. Either way, it’s another thing that they’ll have to address and correct, and Mydei intends to do that right now, approaching him with two fish skewers in hand.

“Phainon.”

Phainon, who had been staring at his new bracelet, raises his head, watching Mydei curiously as the former crown prince sits down beside him. The swordsman once had a healthy appetite, but Mydei knows that nowadays, he won't eat unless prompted—not that either of them need sustenance to begin with—so he presses one of the skewers into his hands, then closes his fingers around it. “Eat.”

Phainon stares at the skewer for a few moments, then raises it to his lips, nibbling it. He seems to like it, so he takes a larger bite, and for a moment, Mydei can see more of his former self in his enthusiasm.

“Is it good?” he asks. Phainon nods, now focused on eating, and Mydei waits for him to finish before he starts talking again. “How are the repairs around Aedes Elysiae?”

“Going well,” Phainon replies. “Looks like how I remember… Wanted to stay, and wait for everyone to come back. But Professor Anaxa said no. I should go back to Okhema first. So he showed me how to use…" His eyebrows furrow as he fights to remember the word he wants. "Wards. They’ll keep the village safe, while we’re gone. Until everyone returns.”

It’s the most Phainon has spoken since his treatment began, so he must be in higher spirits. Even so, Mydei can detect a hint of melancholy in his voice, so he places a hand over his—a reminder that he isn’t alone anymore.

“We will wait together in Okhema,” he promises, squeezing Phainon’s hand. “And when your kin return, we will lead them back to your homeland side-by-side.”

Phainon raises his head again, staring at Mydei, his lips slightly parted in surprise. But he seems to have understood the vow, and he nods, and for the first time since he regained awareness, he squeezes Mydei’s hand in return.

Mydei would be content to spend the rest of their break like that, quietly resting, hand-in-hand. But then, a third voice rings out, interrupting their moment.

“Phainon!”

It’s Cyrene. At the sound of her voice, Phainon immediately raises his head, searching until he finds her waving to him from beneath a large tree. “Come help me out!”

He nods, standing up and walking over to her, and Mydei follows quietly, curious about what she would need help with. When they get to the tiny dock at the foot of the tree, he sees the wooden swing lying tangled amidst a loose coil of rope. It doesn’t seem to be broken otherwise, so it can be tied back onto the branch as is, but a task like that might be quite difficult for Cyrene, who’s quite diminutive in stature. It’s no surprise that she had called for Phainon.

“Lend me your muscles, will you?” she says. “The seat is heavier than it looks!”

Phainon nods again, kneeling down to pick up the wooden plank that serves as the seat and one of the ropes on the ground. However, he pauses after that, staring at the items in his hands without moving. Mydei quickly realizes that in his impaired state, Phainon may not know what to do to fix the swing, so he steps forward and touches his arm to get his attention, then picks up another length of rope.

“Just follow my lead.”

Phainon raises his head, watching as Mydei strings the rope through the hole in the seat, loops it, and ties it into a secure knot. Once Mydei is done, Phainon mimics him. He's a little clumsier than usual, but Mydei can definitely see a shadow of his usual deftness in his movements—a sign that he's getting better.

Once the swing has been reassembled, Mydei and Phainon work together to secure it to its usual branch. After ensuring it's safe to sit on, the two stand back, watching it sway lazily in the wind.

Mydei nods at Cyrene. "It's ready. You can sit on it now."

Delighted, Cyrene trots over and sits down on the swing, then hums happily. "Mmhm~ Good work, you two! It's just like the good old days. It's almost like I'm reliving the past right now."

At that, Mydei glances at Phainon, noticing the flicker of recognition in his eyes. The other man seems to be lost in reverie as he takes in the sight of Cyrene languidly swinging, humming a gentle melody as she does.

"Old days…" he murmurs, and Cyrene nods, smiling at the two.

"Yes. It's thanks to you both. Thank you, Mydei! Thank you, Phainon!"

With your own hands, you were able to recreate what you once destroyed.

The message hidden behind Cyrene's cheerful gratitude doesn't escape Mydei. And judging from the look in Phainon's eyes, the way they soften, he seems to have realized what Cyrene is saying as well.

"...Oracle cards," he says after a brief moment of silence. Cyrene turns to him again.

"Do you want me to do a reading for you?"

Phainon nods, then quietly adds, "The old days. It reminded me."

"Hehe~ Feeling nostalgic, are we? Let's see what fate has in store for you today…" She pulls an odd-looking book out of her bag. "Come a little

closer, you two. I'll do a reading for the two of you together."

Not knowing what to expect, Mydei follows Phainon, and the two of them sit by the swing to wait for Cyrene to finish her reading. He isn't really sure what she's doing, but after some time, she pulls two cards from her book.

"Here they are!"

She lays two cards before the two men, and both of them fall silent.

The first card reads "The Dawn." It displays a colourful image of all the Chrysos Heirs and the Nameless joined hand-in-hand beneath a pale lilac sky. The Phainon depicted on the card seems to have a particularly bright smile on his face, enough to rival the rising sun behind him.

The second card is much simpler, depicting only Mydei and Phainon. In the image shown, the two are facing one another, one of their hands intertwined, the other raised to frame each other's faces. Mydei feels heat spreading across his cheeks when he sees what the title of the card is.

The Lovers.

In contrast to Mydei, Phainon seems a little more clueless, just staring at the cards. It's only when he hears Cyrene giggling that he raises his head.

"Wow~" Cyrene says. "Looks like you two have a joyous, romantic future waiting for you both! Lucky you!"

Mydei isn't sure what to say to that. But Phainon is fixated on something else, watching Cyrene inquisitively. After gathering his thoughts, he speaks again.

"Felt different. The cards too."

"Are you saying that my reading didn't feel like how it usually does?" she asks, and when Phainon nods, she smiles coyly.

"Because it wasn't an actual reading, Phainon."

Phainon blinks at her inquisitively. Similarly confused, Mydei stares at Cyrene, silently demanding answers. For example, if this *wasn't* a reading, where on *earth* had she gotten a card with him and Phainon, specifically, being so intimate with one another?

Perhaps…it was the "gift" that she mentioned not too long ago? The one that she said necessitated Stelle's and March's help? But how did *they* manage to procure something like this?

Amused at both of their expressions, Cyrene winks at Mydei, answering his silent inquiry with a look that very much says *"It's a secret."* Then, she reaches over and flicks Phainon lightly across the forehead. He flinches, recoiling slightly to rub the spot she flicked, now more confused than before.

Cyrene continues speaking, her light and airy tone befitting her youthful features, yet now carrying the weight of wisdom behind it.

"Readings are for people who are bound by fate," she says. "But none of us are chained by fate anymore. We're all free.

"And it's all thanks to you, Phainon."

She meets his eyes and smiles.

"You never gave up on the world we loved. Just like you promised me."

Phainon falls silent, processing her words. There's no indication of whether he fully understands them or not, or how much he actually remembers of the promise that Cyrene speaks of. But when he raises his head to look at Mydei, uncertainty in his eyes, Mydei nods, silently reinforcing Cyrene's remark, encouraging him to take the first step forward into the future he had sacrificed himself endlessly for.

So you live freely too, Phainon. Live for yourself now.

Seeing Mydei's encouragement, Phainon slowly reaches for the two cards, gingerly picking them up and holding them to his chest. A small, gentle

smile spreads across his face, like a flower blooming after a long winter, tinted by the familiar warmth that Mydei has longed to see.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> WE MADE IT..... What a journey it's been. To be honest, I lost confidence so many times while writing this fic because it turned out to be more of an undertaking than I thought it'd be. I actually didn't intend for it to be this long, nor was I thinking of going into so much detail about Phainon's recovery, and including all the Chrysos Heirs (sans Cerydra and Hyselins, since this fic was started before 3.5) was pretty challenging. I did really enjoy writing all the different character interactions, but this was definitely a lot more than what I planned to do with a little angst scenario I came up with on a whim. Hopefully the end result isn't disappointing!
>
> Thank you to everyone for your support! It was fun reading everyone's comments and reactions to everything that happened, and seeing such positive reception was really motivating, even when I was at my lowest. And wow, I can't believe I've gone from writing a one-shot maybe once every six months to finishing multiple multi-chapter fics in not even a year... The power of Amphoreus is amazing...
>
> Finally, I'm aware the CN MyPhai fandom has been reading this fic. Thank you so much for reading! I have a message for any CN readers who happen to be keeping up with updates on AO3 (thank you to Uryan for helping me translate!): 我知道有来自中国的敌厄同担在看这篇同人文，而Uryan给我转发了很多你们的评论。所有的评论都好温暖，而且它们让我更有信心去写完这篇文。谢谢你们这么享受这篇故事！
>
> Anyway, without further ado, here's the final chapter! It's more of an epilogue, so it's a bit shorter, but hopefully satisfying. Once again, thank you for sticking with me for this long!

With the collective efforts of the Chrysos Heirs and the Nameless, Aedes Elysiae is restored.

They spend the latter half of the last day of their trip enjoying the fruits of their labour, passing it in the peace of the sleepy village and the company of one another. When the sun sets, everyone gathers in the Sacrament Courtyard—their evening routine for the past few days—watching the stars on blankets and cushions that Cyrene had unearthed from her old storage chests. It’s warm enough to sleep outside, and one by one, they drift off under the curtain of the night sky and to the sound of comfortable chatter.

Outside of Okhema, Mydei always instinctively falls back on old habits, and he is among the last to fall asleep, remaining on high alert even long after everyone else has gone silent. However, the feeling of Phainon’s warm body in his arms, the sound of his soft breathing, and the gentle, rhythmic rise and fall of his chest eventually lulls Mydei into drowsiness as well, and he, too, drifts off.

When he awakes again, the sky is brighter, but the sun hasn’t yet risen. Still groggy, it takes him a few moments to remember that he’s currently in Aedes Elysiae—

—and for the empty space beside him to completely register.

Startled, he immediately sits up, his head swiveling to and fro. Judging from the colour of the sky, it's still very early in the morning, and everyone is still asleep, but Phainon is nowhere to be found—the swordsman has disappeared completely, as if he never existed in the first place.

Before he can lose himself to his irrational fears (*why, why does an existence completely devoid of Phainon feel so strangely familiar, why does he feel so acquainted with the void that idea opens in his heart, as if he has experienced it before?),* Mydei catches himself. The spot beside him is still warm, which means Phainon had only vacated it recently—and *that* means he couldn’t have gone far. With that in mind, the former crown prince calms down enough to feel disgruntled that Phainon hadn’t woken him up to accompany him, but he figures that it’s very like him to be so unnecessarily considerate.

Not wanting to wake his companions, Mydei slowly rises to his feet and carefully picks his way over the sleeping bundles scattered across the floor. Along with Hyacine, Castorice, Sunday, and Stelle, Mydei and Phainon had fallen asleep on the second floor of the courtyard, giving both of them access to the balcony. Mydei makes his way to the railing now, taking one look at it before vaulting over it, landing lightly on the ground outside the courtyard with barely a sound.

Save for the swaying of wheat stalks in the cool breeze, Aedes Elysiae is still and quiet. He figures Phainon should be easy to find, but even after scanning his surroundings, Mydei doesn't see him in the immediate vicinity of the courtyard. So he takes a slow walk through the empty village, his eyes raking over everything for any sign of activity. He eventually finds them in the form of fresh footprints on one of the dirt paths, matching Phainon's size perfectly. Following them, it doesn't take that much longer for him to notice a figure sitting within the wheat stalks, nearly perfectly concealed, and he wastes no time in walking over. Mydei is normally as silent as a hunter, but this time, he makes sure his footfalls sound a little louder to make his approach known and avoid startling Phainon.

"Well, well, well. Awake so early? That's a surprise. And here I thought you'd be impossible to drag out of bed," he drawls.

Of course, that's blatantly untrue—during the old times, on their days off, Phainon was usually the one who was up and about first, provided he actually managed to fall asleep the night before. But after seeing him smile the other day, Mydei has really begun missing their banter and is filled with the urge to try taunting his lover a little.

Unfortunately but expectedly, Phainon doesn't take the bait, simply looking up at Mydei with a vacant glance. "Mydei…"

Seeing that his provocations had flown over Phainon's head, Mydei makes no further attempt to rile him up, simply crossing his arms and looking down at him sternly. "You should've woken me."

"...Sorry. Wanted to see Aedes Elysiae, before we left. But everyone, seemed tired. Didn't want to make noise."

Mydei supposes that's reasonable enough, though he doubts that anyone would've woken anyway—everyone *is* quite fatigued from the labour they had been carrying out over the past few days, sleeping deeply through the nights. But before he can say anything more to admonish Phainon, the swordsman shuffles to the side, making some room for Mydei to sit. Recognizing the invitation to join him, Mydei obliges, sitting down beside Phainon. From where they are now, they have a perfect view of the glowing horizon, the sea reflecting the sky like a scintillating mirror.

"I remember. This spot," Phainon says after a while. "It's my favourite. Every time I'm born, in every cycle. Here, no one could find me, when I didn't want to be found. No one but Big Snowy."

A beat, before he turns to Mydei. "But you found me."

"Because I will always find you."

Just as Mydei had found Phainon in the failed Strife trial, and just as he had found him now, unearthing him from the grief and pain that had smothered him for an eternity.

"No matter how far away you are, no matter where you go," he promises. "I will always find you."

Phainon's eyes soften. Mydei can't tell whether he remembers the travails of the 33,550,336th cycle or not, but as long as he understands the depths of his fidelity, then that's all that matters. Falling silent once again, the two continue watching as the horizon steadily grows brighter, daybreak approaching Aedes Elysiae.

"...Pretty," Phainon murmurs after a few more moments of silence. "This sight… It's so pretty."

"Do you like it?" Mydei asks. When Phainon nods, he smiles, deciding that now is a good time to reinforce the message that all of the Chrysos Heirs had been trying to convey to him while trying to help him heal.

"This is the dawn that you ushered into Amphoreus, Phainon."

“Wasn’t me,” Phainon replies almost immediately. “It was her. Stelle. The real hero. Her, and all of you.”

“But it’s because of your efforts that she was able to find us. Phainon… You are every bit as much of a hero as she is.” Mydei pauses, then adds, “Nothing less than the Deliverer spoken of in the prophecies.”

Phainon falls quiet, staring pensively at the stalks of wheat swaying in the breeze. Then, unexpectedly, he continues speaking again.

“I troubled, all of you,” he says quietly. “I caused so much pain. Again and again. Then, with Irontomb, at the end. I couldn’t stop it completely. And now… All this. This was for me too. Wasn’t it?” He looks down. “I’m sorry.”

Mydei stares at Phainon pensively, realizing what he's trying to say: that no hero would have to rely so much on others, or so Phainon thinks. With more awareness returning to him than ever, the guilt that Dan Heng had mentioned must be rearing its ugly head, but it’s also so like Phainon to beat himself up over the things he perceives to be burdens on other people. It almost throws Mydei back to the simpler times, when he would just smack Phainon upside the head with his palm and tell him to stop overthinking, but he remembers their circumstances and holds himself back. He probably shouldn’t hit Phainon’s head right now, since that’s where most of the damage is.

Instead, he settles for placing his hand on Phainon’s crown. Then, he pushes his head down, until the action earns him a confused whine and weak squirming. It’s a comical sight, and it makes Mydei smirk crookedly, both in amusement and silent gratitude that he can now enjoy such moments with his beloved after spending so long feeling like he would crumble to dust and ash at the slightest touch.

“Right now, your brain can barely hold enough words for you to string two complete sentences together. Instead of wasting your limited mental capacity on endless apologies, why don’t you spare room for a ‘thank you’ to everyone who’s helped you?” Mydei’s voice softens. “Is it so hard to fathom that they *wanted* you to recover? That you are cherished?”

Phainon pauses, tilting his head slowly until Mydei can see his blue eyes staring at him through the curtain of his white tresses.

“No matter what happened, what’s happening now, or what *will* happen… They will always love you,” Mydei continues, removing his hand from the top of Phainon’s head to cup his cheek instead, tilting his face up once again. “And *I*…

*“**I*** will always love you, Phainon.”

And Mydei knows Phainon *understands* him—that the love he speaks of is a different one from the others, equally enduring yet carrying the weight of unceasing devotion. Though Phainon’s expressions still lack most of their emotion, Mydei can see that recognition in the way his slightly widened eyes glisten, catching the first rays of light that emerge over the horizon. More sunbeams follow, illuminating the clear, pale skies and heralding the sun’s rise, but in spite of the breathtaking sight, Phainon’s gaze remains fixed on Mydei.

“Mydei… This whole time, you’ve been with me?”

“...Not the whole time,” Mydei admits guiltily. “But as much as I could.”

“...Were you sad?” Phainon pauses. “Did I…make you sad?”

Now it’s Mydei’s turn to fall silent. Yes, yes he had felt sad, *anguished* even. And he had felt helpless, agonizingly so. And he had felt *anger,* anger at the world that had forced Phainon to burn himself to cinders, anger at Phainon, who had sacrificed himself and was *still* so willing to sacrifice himself without consideration for those he would leave behind, but mostly, Mydei had felt anger at *himself* for his own ignorance, for not being able to prevent it all from happening in the first place, for allowing his beloved to suffer in silence and solitude for so long.

But he can’t convey all of that, and he has no desire to. He’ll have plenty of time to reconcile his own feelings once Phainon has recovered more, anyway. For now, he only reaches over, an arm settling around Phainon’s shoulders.

"...HKS. Stop wasting your breath asking me foolish questions. The only one you should be worrying about right now is yourself." He pulls Phainon closer, keeping him within his grasp, as if the very action will prevent anything or anyone from ever taking him away again. "If you're truly so concerned, then swear to me that you will stay by my side until you draw your last breath. That's the only way you can make up for it."

Phainon doesn't respond.

Not at first.

But then, he finally nods, snuggling a little closer to Mydei, curling against him. It's all the swordsman can manage at the moment, but even so, Mydei can feel even more of his old self returning in the gesture.

"Mm. I'll stay with you. Forever." Phainon's fingers loosely grip the fabric of Mydei's half-robe. "Promise."

"Idiot. Nothing lasts forever. But…it's true that we both have a lot of time."

Between his status as the Strife demigod and Phainon's powers as both the demigod of Worldbearing and a Lord Ravager—whatever that entails—they *could* potentially have an eternity together. Mydei squeezes Phainon's shoulder, allowing himself a moment to indulge in the thought.

"We will not waste a single second of it."

That is Mydei's promise, resolute, reassuring, and hearing it, Phainon nods again. He doesn't say anything else, resting his head against the crook of Mydei's neck, and Mydei allows the silence to blanket them, simply basking in the cool sea breeze and his beloved's company.

Whether Phainon is able to fully recover from the ordeals he has been through remains to be seen. Somehow, Mydei doubts that he will come away from his suffering without many, many lasting scars. And once the Astral Express leaves Amphoreus, the Nameless will depart with it, and the Chrysos Heirs will no longer be able to ask them for their help. Perhaps

Phainon may even regress without Sunday's tuning to temper the extremes of his negative emotions, or Dan Heng's endless repository of information on possible cures that exist across the sea of stars, or Stelle's stalwart support, her willingness to drop everything to stand with her companions and be their strength.

But just as Phainon had vowed to be there for him, Mydei swears that he will remain by Phainon's side, come what may. And he's confident that the other Chrysos Heirs share similar sentiments—that they will never let Phainon be alone again.

There's no telling what the future holds, but Mydei has never been one to dwell on what is to come. Instead, he is content to enjoy the feeling of Phainon by his side, the knowledge of the allies at his back, and the beginnings of their first real future, starting with the sight of this dawn.

A dawn with the sun.

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